



Hindustan Times

BJP loses Bankipur bastion, fails to unseat Cong in Datia

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PATNA/BHOPAL/NEW DELHI: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) suffered twin setbacks in assembly bypolls on Monday, losing its bastion in Bihar's Bankipur to poll-strategist-turned-politician Prashant Kishor and failing to win back its stronghold of Datia in Madhya Pradesh from the Congress.

The party won the Manjalpur seat in Gujarat.

In Bankipur, a constituency vacated by BJP chief Nitin Nabin who had held the seat since its inception in 2010, Jan Suraj Party (JSP) founder Kishor defeated the party's first-time candidate Neeraj Kumar Sinha by 19,324 votes in a by-election widely seen as a prestige battle for the ruling party.

Making his electoral debut, Kishor secured 64,151 votes. Sinha polled 44,827, and Rashtriya Janata Dal candidate Rekha Kumari 14,273. The victory marked the first electoral success for Kishor's party after it failed to win any of the 238 seats it contested in the 2025 assembly elections and secured just 4% of the votes.

How the bypoll battles panned out

Bankipur, Bihar	Votes
1) Prashant Kishor, Jan Suraj Party	64,151
2) Neeraj Kumar, BJP	44,827
3) Rekha Kumari, RJD	14,273

Datia, Madhya Pradesh	Votes
1) Ghanshyam Singh, Congress	66,757
2) Ashutosh Tiwari, BJP	60,741
3) Damodar Yadav 'Mandal', ASPIKRI	22,527

Manjalpur, Gujarat	Votes
1) Satish Patel, BJP	55,481
2) Bhikubhai Rabari, Congress	24,851
3) NOTA	2,247

"This is a wake-up call for Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Bihar needs a chief minister who can improve education, create jobs and stop migration. Our objective is not to become MLAs for contracts but to ensure Bihar's development," Kishor said.

This was the first electoral test since Samrat Choudhary took over as chief minister from Nitish Kumar, who moved to the Rajya Sabha. The BJP lost Nabin's booth by 19,324 votes. The CM congratulated Kishor

on his victory. "In the grand festival of democracy, the people have chosen Jan Suraj in the Bankipur Assembly by-election. I respect the people's verdict and congratulate Prashant Kishor," he said in a post on X.

In Datia, a seat where the BJP's denial of a ticket to former state minister Narottam Mishra sparked messy infighting during the campaign, the Congress managed to retain the constituency.

Congress's Ghanshyam Singh defeated BJP's Ashutosh Tiwari

by over 6,000 votes, marking his fourth victory in assembly polls in Madhya Pradesh. Singh won Datia twice in 1993 and 2003, and also the neighbouring Seondha seat in 2018. The Azad Samaj Party candidate Damodar Yadav secured third position by bagging 22,527 votes.

In 2023, Congress's Rajendra Bharti had won the seat by 7,742 votes. The seat had fallen vacant after Bharti was sentenced to more than two years in prison in a cooperative bank fraud case in April this year.

But the seat turned into a prestige battle after violent protests in Datia over the denial of ticket to Mishra, who had won Datia thrice on the trot before losing in 2023. BJP workers blocked highways for 24 hours. An FIR was registered against 40 BJP workers for rioting and obstructing officials from performing their duties.

Though Mishra later appealed to workers to accept the decision after meeting chief minister Mohan Yadav and state BJP chief Hemant Khandelwal, his displeasure was evident. He broke down during a rally, warned police during campaigning, and eventually faced a symbolic

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SC panel flags widespread breach of building safety norms in Delhi

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court-appointed monitoring committee on sealing in Delhi has flagged widespread violations of the Capital's Master Plan, building bylaws and fire safety norms, warning that thousands of buildings operating as hotels, coaching centres, restaurants, nursing homes and banquet facilities have effectively become "unsafe buildings" that pose a serious threat to public safety.

In a 39-page report submitted to the Supreme Court, the three-member panel - comprising former Environment Pollution (Prevention and Control) Authority chairman Bhure Lal, major general Som Jhingan and

PANEL SAID THAT THOUSANDS OF BUILDINGS WERE POSING A SERIOUS THREAT TO PUBLIC SAFETY IN CAPITAL

former IAS officer Vijay Chhibber - cited the recent Hauz Rani hotel fire that killed 23 people as evidence of years of unchecked illegal construction and weak enforcement by civic agencies.

The panel made six broad recommendations. It called for a complete overhaul of Delhi's mixed-use policy; a review of the Bed and Breakfast Establishments Act, 2007; a citywide survey to identify commercial activ-

ities operating from unsafe buildings; the withdrawal of MCD circulars permitting social functions in hotels, motels, farmhouses and unauthorised colonies; a random fire safety inspections even in buildings that have already received fire clearances; and the transfer of related cases to the Supreme Court bench already hearing unauthorised construction matters.

The panel - constituted by the apex court in 2006 to monitor unauthorised construction and revived in 2017 - said that it had repeatedly highlighted misuse of residential premises and violations of the Master Plan of Delhi-2021 (MPD-2021), but corrective action had remained inadequate.

INDICES DIVERGE AS NEW AUCTION SYSTEM KICKS IN

MUMBAI: The Nifty and Sensex showed a rare divergence on close of trade on Monday as exchanges adopted a new auction mechanism for stocks with traded futures and option contracts. The Nifty was up 1.6% at 3:30pm on Monday. Sensex closed up 0.7%. SEBI's new Closing Auction Session replaced the earlier method of calculating closing prices for stocks in the F&O segment where closing prices were based on volume-weighted average price of trades in the final 30 minutes of continuous trade.

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AIRLINES REPORT 352 DEFECTS TILL JUNE, AKASA TOPS

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NEW DELHI: A total of 352 significant technical defects were reported in domestic and international flight operations between January and June this year, the government said in a written reply in Rajya Sabha on Monday. Akasa Air reported the highest number of such defects at 152, followed by AIK at 53, IndiGo at 47 and Air India at 46.

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COUPLE DIES IN NE DELHI AS ROOF OF HOUSE COLLAPSES

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NEW DELHI: A couple in their 30s was killed after the roof of their room in a dilapidated single-storey house collapsed on Sunday, officials from the fire and police departments said on Monday. The woman's 10-year-old son from her first marriage, who was hardly 10 steps away, survived because he was in a neighbour's room.

BILL TO EXTEND TAX BREAKS FOR ELECTRONICS MFG

NEW DELHI: A draft bill expected to be tabled in Parliament this week has proposed extending tax exemptions until 2041 for foreign companies that provide machinery to contract manufacturers, handing a major win to Apple, which had lobbied for such changes.

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BHIWANI: INDIA'S BOXING NURSERY DELIVERS AGAIN

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ROHTAK: Known as India's "mini Cuba" for its rich boxing legacy, Haryana's Bhiwani district once again lived up to its reputation, producing one of the country's seven boxing gold medalists at CWG in Glasgow.

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Stalker stabs teacher to death inside school

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GURUGRAM: A 30-year-old teacher was stabbed to death inside a private school in Faridabad on Monday after an alleged stalker dragged her out of a classroom and attacked her in full view of students and staff, police said. CCTV footage showed the assailant stabbing the woman at least 25 times before fleeing. The accused, 21-year-old Amit, was arrested from Kot village in Faridabad about two hours later, still wearing blood-stained clothes, officers said.

Police identified the victim as Sandhya Karhana, a resident of Firozpur Kalan, who taught Class 2 at Saraswati Senior Secondary School in Sikrona. She is survived by her husband and two children.

Investigators said Karhana



The accused stabbed the woman at least 25 times before fleeing.

reached school around 7:30am and was teaching a class when the accused, his face covered with a white cloth, entered the campus through the main gate around 9:35am. According to police, the security guard was not at the entrance at the time, allowing the stalker to enter unchecked.

{ 'WHISKY-FLAVOURED WHISKY' }

FSSAI halts sale of top rum, whisky brands for using artificial flavours; USL moves HC

mint

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NEW DELHI: United Spirits Ltd, maker of McDowell's No.1, Royal Challenge, Antiquity Blue and Signature whisky, has moved the Bombay High Court against an order by the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) restricting the sale of one of its rum products.

The move comes as FSSAI steps up enforcement against

what it says is the misleading use of identical flavouring and age-related claims in alcoholic beverages, a move that could reshape long-standing manufacturing practices across India's Indian Made Foreign Liquor (IMFL) industry.

In a stock exchange filing on Monday, the Diageo India-owned company said it had filed a writ petition challenging FSSAI's June 29 order concerning a product manufactured at its Baramati unit in Maharashtra. The regulator alleged the product labels violated provi-

FSSAI ALLOWS THE USE OF NATURAL FLAVOURING, BUT SOME FACTORIES WERE ADDING FLAVOURS OF THE BEVERAGE ITSELF

sions of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006.

United Spirits said its labels comply with the current legal and regulatory framework and reflect long-standing industry

practice. The petition was filed on August 1. The company said the order has no material operational or financial implications and declined further comment, saying the matter is sub judice.

Under scrutiny

The disclosure came a day after FSSAI, in an official release, defended its enforcement action against several alcoholic beverage manufacturers.

The regulator said the issue is not flavouring substances such as coffee or vanilla, which

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NUMBER THEORY

Why Bankipur bypoll loss will worry the BJP

By Nishant Ranjan and Roshan Kishore

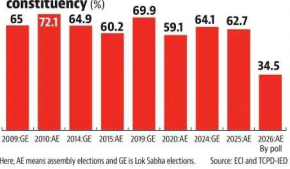
One should not read too much in an isolated bypoll result. But political consultant-turned-politician Prashant Kishor's (PK) victory in Bankipur will worry the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in Bihar. The reasons go beyond the optics of the fact that the assembly constituency (AC) was held by the BJP's current national president Nitin Nabin. Here are some data points which explain the argument.



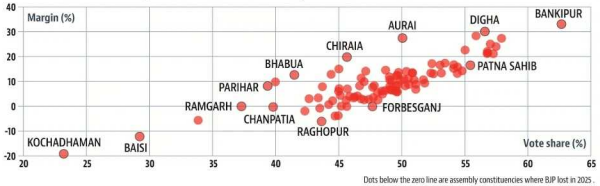
1 Bankipur was a long-time BJP bastion

Nabin became an MLA aged 26 when he contested a by-poll which was necessitated by the death of his father, Nabin Kishor Prasad Sinha, one of the BJP's most important leaders of his generation. At the time of his passing in 2006, Nabin Kishore Prasad Sinha had been a four-time MLA from Patna West AC, large parts of which became part of the Bankipur AC after the 2008 delimitation. In the 8 assembly and Lok Sabha elections in Bankipur since the 2009 Lok Sabha polls, the BJP has never lost this seat even once and had polled a minimum of 59.1% vote share in this AC. This makes its latest vote share of 34.4%, the lowest ever by a distance. Even in the 2025 assembly elections, the BJP's vote share in Bankipur was the highest in all 101 ACs which it contested.

BJP vote share in Bankipur assembly constituency (%)



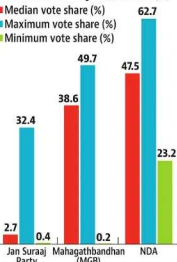
BJP vote share vs margin in 2025 Bihar assembly elections (BJP contested 101 ACs and won 89)



2 Kishor's party performed extremely poorly during its debut in the 2025 elections

While PK received disproportionate limelight in the 2025 elections as well, the results were extremely disappointing for his party which polled just 3.4% vote share in state as a whole. PK himself did not even contest the elections, which many saw as a sign of him chickening out of the contest fearing a loss. Overall vote share aside, there was very little in terms of a silver lining for PK and his party even in AC-wise contests. The best performance by a Jan Suraj Party (JSP) candidate in 2025 was in Marhaura assembly constituency with a vote share of 32.4%. JSP did not even finish second in any AC in the state. To lose its safest bastion in the state to a party which failed to make any mark in its debut elections, and not some strong established opposition party, will hurt the BJP even more.

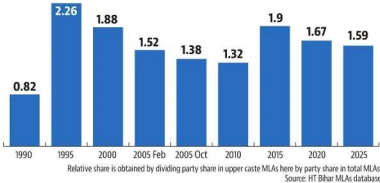
Median, maximum, and minimum vote share in 2025 Bihar assembly elections (%)



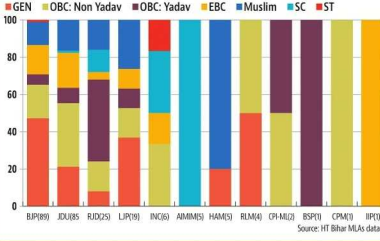
3 At the core of the BJP's worries will be the tension in its upper caste base

The first author of this story has built multiple original databases which show that the BJP has done much better than its competitors, especially the Congress, in giving representation to Other Backward Classes (OBCs) in the legislature and the executive. It is this social engineering which has allowed the BJP to surge ahead of its competitors in many states. However, Bihar is one state where the BJP has also enjoyed an overwhelming support from upper castes and maintained a quid-pro-quo of representation to preserve this deal. This is best seen in the BJP's large advantage in share of upper caste MLAs, both historically and currently in Bihar, as was shown by the historical caste database of MLAs in Bihar. PK's Bankipur victory over the BJP will also be seen as an upper caste challenger - PK comes from the Brahmin sub-caste - defeating the BJP in one of its biggest upper caste bastions. His victory will embolden the BJP's upper caste supporters to argue that the party needs to do more to retain their support. Erring on the other side of the demand carries the risk of alienating the BJP's newly developed and expanding OBC base in the state, which is exemplified in the choice of its current chief minister.

BJP relative share in Hindu upper caste MLAs in Bihar



Socio-religious composition of partywise MLAs in 2025 assembly elections (%)



Neither of the data points described above should be inferred as the sign of a pre-ordained decline of the BJP or a meteoric rise of the JSP in the state. What they do tell us is that the NDA in Bihar, now under the leadership of BJP and Samrat Choudhary, will have to work harder to preserve its 'coalition of extremes' than worked for it under its original architect, Nitish Kumar, who is now, quasi-retired from politics.

{ SPORT } WC SELL-OFF PLAN COLLAPSES

Embattled Fifa prez snubbed by Trump



Fifa President Gianni Infantino sought support from the Trump administration amid mounting criticism after his abandoned plan to sell a stake in World Cup commercial rights, the New York Post said on Monday. It reported that Infantino had repeatedly tried and failed to reach US President Donald Trump by phone since the proposal collapsed, and the Fifa chief felt "isolated" by negative media coverage. A source close to the president said that while the president's staff said there were "no plans for (Marcelo) Rubio to speak to Infantino and there is no call" which has been scheduled.

-PFA

{ MY INDIA } LOWER THAN 2025 LEVEL

Kharif sowing lags despite July rains



The sowing of the monsoon crop (kharif) across India remained below last year's level despite an improvement in July rainfall, with farmers planting crops in 105.2 million hectares as of July 31, 3.6% lower than a year ago, as the delayed onset of southwest monsoon and uneven rainfall distribution continued to weigh on planting decisions. According to experts, this is likely to impact total food output. The weather office has predicted below-normal rainfall in August and September, with stronger El Niño conditions.

-PFI

{ MY INDIA } PLEA FILED BY PUNE RESIDENT

HC weighs plea to freeze eggs without husband's consent



The Bombay High Court has directed the National Assisted Reproductive Technology (ART) and Surrogacy Board to consider a plea filed by a Pune resident seeking permission to freeze her eggs without her husband's consent, which is required under the ART Act. A division bench of the court, headed by Chief Justice Dr. D. Y. Chandrachud, said the appropriate authorities would examine the plea if the petitioner filed a proper application. The bench asked Dr. D. Y. Chandrachud to decide the matter within three weeks.

-PFI

{ MY INDIA } FOR SHARE OF WATER

TN govt moves SC amid Cauvery row



The chief minister Vijay-led TN government on Monday moved the Supreme Court seeking directions to Karnataka for immediate release of the share of Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu. The application contended that Karnataka had "willfully" disobeyed the directions issued by the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) and the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC), despite improved storage levels following recent rainfall in the Cauvery catchment.

-PFI

{ BUSINESS } SEBI REQUIREMENT

Govt to sell 6.5% LIC stake in offer for sale



The government will sell up to a 6.5% stake in LIC through a sale offer, the Department of Investment and Public Asset Management secretary said in a post on X on Monday. The offer comprises a base size of up to 2% equity, with an option to sell an additional 4.5% stake. The floor price has been set at ₹382 per share. LIC shares ended at ₹428.50 on Monday. The stake will be sold to achieve the minimum SEBI-mandated public shareholding requirement ahead of schedule. SEBI had given LIC time till May 16 next year to achieve the 10% public shareholding. The government currently holds a 96.5% stake in LIC.

-PFI

Hasina's Aug 5 event can hit ties with India: B'desh

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NEW DELHI: Bangladesh believes former prime minister Sheikh Hasina's plans to address a new conference in New Delhi can undermine the positive momentum in relations with India, a top aide of the Bangladesh Prime Minister told Indian high commissioner Dinesh Trivedi on Monday.

Humaun Kobar, adviser on foreign affairs to Prime Minister Rahman, conveyed the message to Trivedi during a meeting at the Prime Minister's Office in Dhaka, according to a statement from Bangladesh's foreign ministry. The development came two days before a planned virtual news conference by Hasina on August 5, exactly two years after she fled to India after the collapse of her government.

Kobar told Trivedi that Bangladesh "expects India's cooperation in ensuring that no individual—including the fugitive Hasina or members of organisations whose activities have been banned—uses Indian territory to deliver political statements or conduct activities aimed at destabilising the situation within Bangladesh", the statement said.

He also "noted that such activities could undermine the positive progress of bilateral relations," according to the statement issued in Bengal.

The statement quoted Trivedi as saying that the "matter would be duly considered, necessary inquiries made, and active attention paid to the issue".

The high commissioner said on social media that Trivedi reiterated India's "intent to work positively with the government of

Bangladesh to advance the developmental aspirations of the peoples of India and Bangladesh".

The discussion "focused on increasing people-centric cooperation between the two neighbouring countries, based on mutual interest and mutual benefit", according to the social media post.

Hasina is expected to detail her plans to return to Bangladesh at her first virtual interaction with the media in New Delhi, which will be held on August 5, according to the Bangladesh Correspondents Club in the evening on August 5. She will "announce her homecoming and outline her vision for Bangladesh", according to the organisers of the event.

The 78-year-old former premier, who has lived in self-exile in India since August 2024, has said in recent interviews that she intends to go back to Bangladesh by December and surrender to the courts.

Party (BNP) government has sought Hasina's extradition, and the Indian side has said the request will be considered in line with legal and judicial processes.

The statement from Bangladesh's foreign ministry further said that Kobar and Trivedi reviewed various aspects of bilateral relations and discussed issues of mutual interest. They expressed optimism about further strengthening of the language and approach relations based on mutual respect, trust and shared interests, it said.

THREAT, PAUSE, REPEAT:

Trump's shifting Iran rhetoric

From ultimatums to pauses, Donald Trump has repeatedly escalated his threats against Iran before stepping back. Here's how his stance changed as the West Asia conflict unfolded:

ULTIMATUM OVER HORMUZ
March 21: Trump warned that if Iran did not reopen the Strait of Hormuz within 48 hours, the US would strike and destroy Iranian power plants, which is widely considered a war crime.

THREATS INTENSIFY, THEN PAUSE
April 8: As the revised deadline approached, Trump renewed his demand that Iran reopen Hormuz with a profanity-laden post, threatening that "you'll be living in hell" for not complying.

April 7: "A whole civilization will die tonight, never to be brought back again," Trump announced in a post that many interpreted as a threat to wipe out Iran.

Hours later: The same day, the US President announced a two-week suspension of planned attacks on Iran after accepting a truce proposal from war mediators.

STRIKE ON... STRIKE OFF
June 11: Trump announced that the US would be "hitting Iran very hard tonight" and said Iranian oil infrastructure, including Kharg Island, would be taken over.

Five hours later: He said he had cancelled the planned strikes, citing progress in negotiations toward an agreement to end the conflict.

A fragile truce: An interim agreement ended the fighting temporarily, but within a month the conflict reignited.

ANOTHER WARNING, ANOTHER RETREAT
July 31: Trump told a meeting of his cabinet that the US would "strike Iran very hard." "And you know at some point they're going to say, we just can't take it anymore," he was quoted as saying.

August 1: He claimed Iran and other West Asian countries had requested the US to delay any attack because the outlines of a deal had been agreed. Iran's state media denied making any such request.

Bil seeks to extend tax break for contract manufacturing till '41

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NEW DELHI: The government has proposed legislation extending tax exemptions until 2041 for foreign companies that provide machinery to contract manufacturers, handing a major win to Apple, which has lobbied for such changes, and is fast expanding in the market.

India has been a key market for Apple as it diversifies (iPhone manufacturing beyond China, and the country is set to make 26% of the world's iPhones in 2026, up from 6% today), according to Counterpoint Research.

According to a draft of the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, to provide (tax certainty) the government has extended tax breaks until March 31, 2041 to foreign companies that provide equipment to their contract manufacturers in India.

The government introduced the tax exemption for foreign companies in February, valid only until 2026, to provide (tax certainty) the government has extended tax breaks until March 31, 2041 to foreign companies that provide equipment to their contract manufacturers in India.

profits to tax.

The extended tax exemption will apply to manufacturers of mobile phones, tablets, laptops, hearing and wearable electronic devices, according to the draft bill that is expected to be introduced in Parliament this week.

The bill proposes a series of amendments to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, the Income Tax Act, 2025, and the Finance Act, 2026 and will replace the Income Tax (Amendment) Ordinance, 2026.

The proposed amendment to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, provides the way for the government, through notification, to exempt charges on "one or more" electronic modes of payment. Currently, no bank or system provider can impose charges on electronic modes of payment prescribed under section 269SD of the Income Tax Act, 1961, which include UPI payments and RuPay debit card transactions.

The government has also exempted from tax foreign companies' income from providing parts used to manufacture such electronics components to contract manufacturers until 2041. It has also proposed to exempt contract manufacturers that use data centre services in the country to make use of tax exemptions. The bill now allows data centres to be leased, rather than owned, by foreign companies.

SC panel for revamp of language adopted in sexual offence cases

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NEW DELHI: It is "unpardonable and impermissible in any civilised society" to judge a woman by the clothes she wears or draw conclusions about her virtue, modesty or character, an expert committee constituted pursuant to Supreme Court directions has said, recommending a sweeping overhaul of the language and approach adopted by judges in sexual offence cases to eliminate stereotypes and prevent the secondary victimisation of survivors.

The committee, headed by former Supreme Court Justice Anirudh Bose, has called for the creation of a new "language ecosystem" in the judiciary that replaces patriarchal, moralistic and stigmatising expressions with neutral, survivor-centric terminology.

Its report, "Judgments and Gender: Sensitivity and Compassion in Writing Judgments," was prepared after analysing 125 trial court judgments from across the country with assistance from State Judicial Academies.

The report is the outcome of the February 10 directions by a bench headed by CJ Surya Kant in a suo motu case to revise judicial practices in sexual offence cases after controversial observations made by the Allahabad High Court. The committee comprised former Gujarat High Court Justice Sonia Gokani, former Madhya Pradesh director general of police Anuradha Shankar, Supreme Court advocate Saurabh Singh and anthropologist Lucy TV Zephur.

The panel said that judicial language is not merely a matter of style but "shapes justice" by influencing how survivors experience the legal process and how society understands sexual violence.

It urged courts to stop using expressions such as "prosecutrix," "helpless woman," "poor helpless minor girl," "lost her chastity," "victim of another person's lust," "outraged her modesty," "destroyed her life," "spoiled her childhood," "woman in a non-permissive society," and references to a woman's "honour," "shame," "sacredness" or "chastity". Instead, it recommended the use of terms such as "victim," "survivor," "complainant," "sexual assault," "sexual violence," "violation of bodily autonomy," and "bodily autonomy," observing that these expressions recognise dignity and constitutional rights instead of reinforcing patriarchal notions.

The committee also advised judges against using words such as "whore," "fallen woman," "mistress," "concubine," "kept," "call girl" or "prostitute," recommending "partner" and "sex worker" wherever appropriate, except where statutory terminology requires otherwise. Making a strong case against victim blaming, the report underlined that survivors routinely face intrusive questions throughout the criminal justice process about why they were outside at a particular time, why they were certain clothes, why they delayed reporting the offence or why they were not accompanied by male relatives.

THE PANEL CALLED TO CREATE A NEW 'LANGUAGE ECOSYSTEM' THAT REPLACES PATRIARCHAL EXPRESSIONS WITH NEUTRAL, SURVIVOR-CENTRIC TERMINOLOGY

"It is unpardonable and impermissible in any civilised society to judge a woman solely based on her clothing or to draw conclusions about her virtue or modesty," said the committee, stressing that such assumptions place in place judicial decision-making. Judicial findings, it said, must be founded on evidence and not on stereotypes or preconceived notions about how a victim of sexual violence is expected to behave.

The report lays down nine broad principles to guide judicial writing in sexual offence cases. These include ensuring that findings are evidence-based; exercising caution while using statutory expressions such as "outraging modesty" or "minors"; replacing gendered language using gender-neutral and survivor-centric terminology; referring to victims through the POCSO Act as "child" or "minor"; replacing "prosecutrix" with "victim" or "survivor"; avoiding sensational or moralistic descriptions; focusing on autonomy, consent and child rights and recognising the enduring psychological and physical trauma suffered by survivors.

It reiterates that absence of injuries, delayed reporting or lack of physical resistance cannot be equated with consent.

Apart from reforming judicial language, the committee recommended a series of courtroom practices aimed at making the justice system more sensitive to survivors. It said judges should ensure that victims receive legal aid from the FIR stage, facilitate access to victim compensation schemes, conduct in-camera proceedings wherever required by law, proactively delay handling of sensitive applications, and a trauma-informed approach to courtroom management. Witnesses, it said, should be treated as "guests" of the court rather than being made to spend long hours waiting to testify, a practice that weakens both the justice delivery system and public confidence in courts.

Calling sensitivity "an ongoing process," the committee underlined that judicial training should continuously address unconscious bias and gender stereotypes. Quoting the Supreme Court's observations in SP Gupta Vs Union of India (1983), it said the true independence of a judge lies in overcoming personal prejudices through education, training and humility.

Justice Liberhan, who led Babri probe, dies at 87

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NEW DELHI: Justice Manmohan Singh Liberhan, a former chief justice of the Andhra Pradesh and Madras high courts who headed the panel probing the demolition of the Babri Masjid in 1992, died in Chandigarh on Sunday, He was 87.

Born on November 11, 1938, near Chandigarh, Justice Liberhan began practising at the Punjab and Haryana high court in 1964 before getting elevated to the bench.

He was elevated to the Chandigarh in the presence of friends, family and colleagues. "My first appointment in the Punjab and Haryana high court was before him, in August 1992," said Anu Chattrath, senior additional advocate general for Punjab.

"He was a highly motivating judge and made others feel at ease. I remember whenever the atmosphere would become tense in court, he would crack a witty one-liner," Chattrath added.

Justice Liberhan was elected to the Punjab and Haryana bar council in August 1970 and served as its member until February 11, 1987. He was appointed chief justice of the Madras high court on July 7, 1997 and chief justice of the Andhra Pradesh high court on February 28, 1998.



Justice MS Liberhan HT ARCHIVE

extensions for the Liberhan Commission to deliver the report on June 30, 2009, making it among the longest-running judicial inquiries.

In his report, Justice Liberhan stated that destruction was premeditated, systematic, and a planned conspiracy executed by multiple individuals, including political figures and others part of right-wing organisations.

"It stands established beyond doubt that the events of the day were neither spontaneous nor unplanned nor an unforeseen overflowing of the people's emotion, nor the result of a foreign conspiracy as some overly imaginative people have tried to suggest," the 1,029-page report said.

DKS inducts 9 ministers in cabinet, strength up by 33

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BENGALURU: Karnataka's long-awaited cabinet expansion took shape on Monday with the induction of 19 ministers, bringing the strength of the chief minister DK Shivakumar-led council of ministers to 33, even as the cabinet continues to have no women's representation. Meanwhile, a Congress legislator resigned from his post over his exclusion from the cabinet by Governor Thawar Chand Gehlot administered the oath of office and secrecy to new ministers in a ceremony held at the Lok Bhavan premises in Bengaluru.

The cabinet expansion brought together experienced legislators and first-time ministers, but the final list underwent changes in the hours before the ceremony. Among the notable omissions were MLC Gayathri Shantegowda, whose name was on the final list cleared by the Congress high command but was dropped at the last moment, leaving the state cabinet without a woman minister. Bhatkal Rajappa Mankal Vaidya, whose name appeared in an earlier list issued by the AICC, was replaced by former minister SS Mallikarjun. People familiar with the development said Gayathri, a



CM DK Shivakumar with newly inducted ministers on Monday.

Kuruba leader, was kept out after former chief minister Siddaramaiah raised concerns that he was not consulted on the appointment. Shivakumar was sworn-in as the chief minister along with 13 ministers on June 3, following Siddaramaiah's resignation as CM on May 28. The sanctioned strength of Karnataka's council of ministers is 34, including the CM. After the expansion, the cabinet now has one vacant berth. Among the first-time ministers inducted on Monday are Mayakonda MLA KS Basavanthappa, T Raghunath (Chalakeri), Rizwan Arshad (Shivajinagar), Ajay Singh (Jevangi), K M Shivalingu Gowda (Arasikere), HC Balakrishna (Magadi), and Vijayanand Kashappanavar (Bagalkote).

Those who were part of the earlier Siddaramaiah-led cabinet include Shivraj Tagadagi (Kannakuragi), B Nagendra (Bailari rural), BD Zameer Ahmed Khan (Chamarajpet), Santosh Lakshmi (Kallaghatagi), and N Chaluvaraya Swamy (Nagannur). Though Siddaramaiah was conspicuously absent from the oath-taking ceremony, the cabinet's regional distribution reflects its continuing influence, particularly in Old Mysuru region, which accounts for

11 ministers. The Congress also cleared GS Patil as speaker of the legislative assembly, AS Ponanna as deputy speaker, Saleem Ahmed as chairman of the legislative council and Umashree as deputy chairperson. The Congress also aimed to preserve the social balance in the cabinet expansion, with Lingayats and Scheduled Castes having been given representation with seven ministers each accounting for 21.2% of the extended cabinet. B Nagendra (ST), who had resigned from former chief minister Siddaramaiah's cabinet after his name surfaced in the

multi-crore financial scam in Valmiki Development Corporation and was later arrested, has made a comeback. The cabinet also carries the imprint of political families, with three children of former CMs getting a ministerial berth. They include Yathindra Siddaramaiah, son of Siddaramaiah, Madhu Bangarappa, son of S Bangarappa, and Dr Ajay Singh, son of N Dharani Singh.

The expansion, however, left several Congress legislators dissatisfied. Indu MIA Yashwanthayagouda V Patil resigned after missing out on a cabinet berth, while Sagar MIA Belur Gopalakrishna also announced his resignation. HC Mahadevappa, HK Patil, Dinesh Gundu Rao, K Venkatesh, MC Sudhakar and Laxmi Hebbalkar were among the other notables seen in Congress leaders left outside the cabinet. "It is disappointing that after so many years of service to the state and the party, I have not been considered to serve the government in this cabinet. I am disappointed by decisions taken without being given any reason for my exclusion," Dinesh Gundu Rao said in a post on X. Ahead of the expansion, Shivakumar appealed to disappointed legislators to remain patient, recalling his own wait for a ministerial position.

"It is disappointing that after so many years of service to the state and the party, I have not been considered to serve the government in this cabinet. I am disappointed by decisions taken without being given any reason for my exclusion," Dinesh Gundu Rao said in a post on X. Ahead of the expansion, Shivakumar appealed to disappointed legislators to remain patient, recalling his own wait for a ministerial position.

CM raises presence of Muslims, Dalits in govt

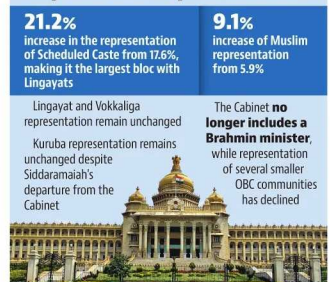
Arun Dev
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BENGALURU: Chief minister DK Shivakumar has expanded his Cabinet without altering the Congress's core social coalition, retaining the party's traditional support among Lingayats and Vokkaligas while increasing representation for Scheduled Castes and Muslims.

An analysis of the 33 member ministry shows that Lingayats remain the single largest community in the Cabinet with seven ministers, accounting for 21.2% of the ministry. Vokkaligas, CM's own community, continue to hold five berths, or 15.2%, preserving the representation of Karnataka's two dominant political communities. Congress leaders familiar with the discussions said the leadership sought continuity rather than a wholesale restructuring of the ministry. "The objective was continuity with some course correction, not a complete overhaul," a senior Congress leader said on the condition of anonymity.

The most visible change is in Scheduled Caste representation. The Cabinet now has seven Scheduled Caste ministers, up from six, raising the community's share from 17.6% in the previous ministry to 21.2%. The expansion brings Scheduled Castes on par with Lingayats as the largest social bloc in the government. The Cabinet includes G Parameshwara, HK Muniyappa, Priyank Kharge, Narendranavara, Shivraj Tagadagi, Radhappa Laman and KS Basavanthappa. Muslim representation has also increased from two ministers to three, lifting the community's share from 5.9% to 9.1% through the inclusion of Rizwan Arshad joined UT Khader and Zameer Ahmed Khan. Kuruba representation

Key shifts in representation



remains unchanged at two ministers despite Siddaramaiah's exit from the Cabinet. The community is represented by Yathindra Siddaramaiah and Byrathi Suresh. Although as per the initial list, Gayathri Shantegowda, a Kuruba leader, was named in the new cabinet, however, the name did not make it. Scheduled Tribe representation remains unchanged at three ministers, or 9.1% of the Cabinet, through Satish Jagdish, B Nagendra and T Raghunath. Party leaders said the Congress was careful not to dilute Lingayat representation despite the change in leadership. Along with MB Patil, Sharan Prakash Patil and Eshwar Khandre, the Cabinet includes Basavappa Rayanahalli, Vijayanand Kashappanavar and Laxman Savadi, maintaining the community's seven member strength. The Vokkaliga bloc has been retained through Shivakumar,

Krishna Byre Gowda, N Cheluvaryaswamy, KM Shivalingu Gowda and HC Balakrishna. The changes are more pronounced among smaller communities. Representation from several OBC groups has declined compared to the previous ministry. Communities such as Vokkaligas and Kshatriyas no longer have Cabinet representation, while Maratha, Ediga, Uppara and Rajput communities continue to have one minister each. The Cabinet also no longer includes a Brahmin minister following the exclusion of Dinesh Gundu Rao. Christian and Reddy representation remains unchanged with one minister each. Congress functionaries involved in the consultations said the final composition was intended to preserve the party's electoral coalition while accommodating new entrants and regional interests.

No woman in cabinet after Gayathri's name dropped from final expansion list

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BENGALURU: Karnataka's expanded Congress Cabinet took shape on Monday without a woman minister after Gayathri Shantegowda, the only woman included in the list approved by the party leadership, was left out before the swearing-in ceremony.

Gayathri Shantegowda's exclusion became the most notable change in the final composition. Those familiar with the development said Gayathri, a Kuruba leader, was kept out after former chief minister Siddaramaiah raised concerns that he had not been consulted on the appointment.

Siddaramaiah was absent from the oath-taking ceremony, however, the Cabinet's regional distribution reflected his continuing influence, particularly in Old Mysuru.

BJP state president BV Vijayendra said the Congress over women's representation in the cabinet. "You, who spoke grandly about women, opposed the central government's women's bill, and now in the cabinet, you've given a place to just a single woman—what kind of concern is this for women's issues?" he asked.

"The people will teach a fitting lesson in the coming days to this government that opposes women and fosters corruption," he said in a post on X. Senior Congress leader Margaret Alva also voiced concern



Gayathri Shantegowda

over the composition of the ministry. In a post on X, she said, "I would have loved to see at least one Congress woman in the new Karnataka Cabinet sworn in today. Deeply disappointed that there isn't one."

Responding to the criticism, Shivakumar said, "Let them (BJP) wait; there are a lot of vacancies. Last time, too, there were no women in the first round. We are all there."

The region accounts for 11 ministers, the largest share in the 33 member ministry. Several leaders associated with him, including PM Narendranavara, N Cheluvaryaswamy, KM Shivalingu Gowda and C Puttappa, have entered the government.

The Congress also cleared GS Patil as speaker of the Legislative Assembly, AS Ponanna as deputy speaker, Saleem Ahmed as chairman of the Legislative Council and Umashree as deputy chairperson. The new ministers took the oath before Governor Thawar

chand Gehlot at Lok Bhavan in Bengaluru. The expansion brought together experienced legislators and first-time ministers, but the final list underwent changes in the hours before the ceremony. Bhatkal MIA Mankal Vaidya, whose name appeared in an earlier list issued by the All India Congress Committee, was replaced by former minister SS Mallikarjun. The expanded ministry also preserves the Congress' existing social balance. Lingayats and Scheduled Castes have emerged as the largest community groups in the expanded Cabinet, with seven ministers each accounting for 21.2% of the 33-member cabinet.

While Lingayat representation remains unchanged, Scheduled Caste gains have gained one additional berth compared to the previous ministry, increasing their share from 17.6% to 21.2%. Vokkaligas hold five positions, or 15.2%, continuing the representation of Karnataka's two dominant political communities. Muslim representation has also grown from two ministers to three, lifting the community's share from 5.9% to 9.1% through the inclusion of Rizwan Arshad joined UT Khader and Zameer Ahmed Khan.

B Nagendra (ST), who had resigned from former chief minister Siddaramaiah's cabinet after his name surfaced in the multi-crore financial scam in Valmiki Development Corporation and was later arrested, has made a comeback. The Cabinet also carries the

imprint of political families. Three ministers are children of former chief ministers: Yathindra Siddaramaiah, son of Siddaramaiah; Madhu Bangarappa, son of S Bangarappa; and Dr Ajay Singh, son of N Dharani Singh. The expansion left several Congress leaders dissatisfied. Indu MIA Yashwanthayagouda V Patil resigned after missing out on a Cabinet berth, while Sagar MIA Belur Gopalakrishna also announced his resignation. HC Mahadevappa, HK Patil, Dinesh Gundu Rao, K Venkatesh, MC Sudhakar and Laxmi Hebbalkar were among the senior Congress leaders left outside the cabinet.

Dinesh Gundu Rao expressed disappointment over his exclusion from the Karnataka cabinet, questioning the lack of transparency in the decision-making process. "It is disappointing that after so many years of service to the state and the party, I have not been considered to serve the government in this cabinet. I am disappointed by decisions taken without being given any reason for my exclusion," Rao wrote in a post on X.

Ahead of the expansion, Shivakumar appealed to disappointed legislators to remain patient, recalling his own wait for a ministerial position. "We have many aspirants, and many MLAs are deserving. At times, the party has to reject some aspirants to maintain the social balance. In 2004, I too was not inducted into the Cabinet," he said.

MINISTERS TOLD TO INSPECT FLOOD, DROUGHT-HIT DISTRICTS, SAYS CM

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BENGALURU: Karnataka chief minister D K Shivakumar on Monday said his cabinet colleagues have been directed to visit their assigned districts, assess the flood and drought situation, and submit reports to the state government to facilitate relief measures.

Addressing reporters at the Cabinet meeting after Vidhana Soudha, following the expansion of his-led ministry, Shivakumar said the ministers have been instructed to inspect affected areas along with elected representatives from all political parties.

"The Cabinet discussed the challenges before us, including the drought situation and water scarcity in the Cauvery basin. Recent rains have brought temporary relief, but the threat of drought has not completely disappeared," he said. Heavy rainfalls in the Cauvery basin, he said, have caused 30,000 cases of water to Tamil Nadu because of increased inflows, though the KRS.

Shivakumar said Karnataka would continue to monitor the situation and take necessary steps to ensure that the water supply to Tamil Nadu is not affected. He also said that the government would be providing relief to the affected areas.

M'luru-B'luru train services resume after suspension over landslides

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MANGALURU: Train services between Mangaluru and Bengaluru resumed on Monday night after remaining suspended for two days due to landslides triggered by heavy rain in the Western Ghats, officials said.

Rail traffic on the route was restored after railway personnel cleared mud, boulders and debris from the tracks.

Resumed operations were the Vijayapura-Mangaluru Express, KSR Bengaluru-Karwar Panchaganga Express, KSR Bengaluru-Kozhikode Express and SMVT Bengaluru-Murdeswar Express. However, the Karwar-KSR Bengaluru Panchaganga Express (06596) remained cancelled on Monday owing to the non-availability of a rake, railway officials said. The railway administration

RAIL TRAFFIC ON THE ROUTE WAS RESTORED AFTER RAILWAY PERSONNEL CLEARED MUD, BOULDERS AND DEBRIS FROM THE TRACKS

launched an intensive restoration exercise immediately after receiving reports of the landslide. Relief trains, engineering staff, JCB excavators and other heavy machinery were deployed to the affected site, where work continued round the clock to remove mud and rocks from the track, informed MTRCL. Engineers also strengthened the vulnerable slope using sandbags before certifying the track safe for train operations. As the restoration work was completed on Monday evening, most trains that resumed services on Monday night were delayed by around two hours or more, officials said. Following the suspension of services through the ghat section, the Railways ordered the KSR Bengaluru-Kozhikode-KSR Bengaluru and SMVT Bengaluru-Murdeswar-SMVT Bengaluru Expresses via Shoranur and Palakkad.

KRS reservoir crosses 100-ft-mark after a week of heavy downpour

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BENGALURU: The Krishnareddy KRS reservoir in Mandya district crossed the 100 foot mark on Monday, with sustained inflow from the Cauvery catchment areas lifting the water level by nearly 10 ft in a week. The reservoir stood at 100.34 feet at 8 am on August 3, against its full reservoir level of 124.80 feet. The rise followed heavy rainfall in parts of Kodagu.

The improvement in storage across Cauvery basin reservoirs has brought relief to farmers, as water availability improved after the revival of monsoon conditions. The Harangi reservoir in Kodagu also recorded higher inflows, with 11,646 cusecs entering the dam and an outflow of 10,750 cusecs on August 3. The reservoir's level was 2,857.01 feet against its maximum capacity of 2,859 feet. The outflow from Harangi on the same day last year was 3,000 cusecs. The rise in KRS levels is typically quicker until the reservoir reaches 100 feet. Beyond that point, the increase slows as the spread of the backwaters expands. Rainfall activity in Kodagu declined on Monday, with the district recording an average of 19.52 mm rainfall in the 24 hours ending at 8 am. Bhagmandala received 60.90 mm, Madikeri recorded 54.40 mm and Sampaje recorded 67.60 mm.

The Cauvery basin has partially submerged. The river water is inching closer to 'Mudi Katte' near the famous Srikrishnawar Temple in the temple town. The surrounding area of the river bank in the town have been flooded, with the people restricted from going near the swollen river and the bathing ghat. 24-hour warning was issued for the safety of the people.

THE RESERVOIR STOOD AT 100.34 FEET AT 8 AM ON AUGUST 3, AGAINST ITS FULL RESERVOIR LEVEL OF 124.80 FEET. THE RISE FOLLOWED HEAVY RAINFALL IN PARTS OF KODAGU

MINISTER DIRECTS OFFICIALS TO CHALLENGE PLEA ON CAUVERY ROW

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BENGALURU: Karnataka Water Resources Minister Ramalinga Reddy on Monday directed district officials to challenge a plea filed by the Tamil Nadu government in the Supreme Court alleging that Karnataka violated the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) order.

The State government will file an appeal against Tamil Nadu's petition, Reddy said. The minister also noted that Karnataka are already full and excess water is currently flowing out and reaching Tamil Nadu. The development comes amid ongoing disputes between the two States over sharing of Cauvery water and compliance with CWMA directives. Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay instructed the State government to approach the SC after Karnataka failed to release the mandated share of water despite directions issued by the CWMA and CWRC.

Priyank clarifies comment on police recruitment exams

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BENGALURU: Karnataka home minister Priyank Kharge faced backlash on Monday over his remark that he would resign only after the police recruitment examination aspirants go on a 25-day hunger strike and face lathicharges, leading to his resignation. He said he would resign only after the NEET paper leak, he said. The minister later clarified that his comments were directed at the BJP and not the students. His remarks came amid allegations of confusion and disruption at centres in Vijayapura district during the recruitment exam held on Sunday.

"I will resign, but first let the aspirants go on a 25-day hunger strike, lathicharge them, and then I will resign, just as they did after the NEET paper leak," he said. The minister later clarified that his comments were directed at the BJP and not the students. His remarks came amid allegations of confusion and disruption at centres in Vijayapura district during the recruitment exam held on Sunday. "The question put to me was: 'If the BJP and the leader of the Opposition, R Ashoka, are demanding your resignation over the Vijayapura incident. What do you have to say?' My remarks were directed solely at the BJP's political theatrics and not at students," Kharge wrote



Priyank Kharge

led by false news spread on social media. The false claim was that the OMR sheet number and question paper number must be the same," the authority said in a statement. KEA said no official notification, instruction booklet or verbal instruction required the OMR number and question paper number on the OMR sheet. "There is no rule that the OMR number and question paper number have to match. Hence, the public is requested not to spread false news," it added. The confusion led to protests at Sri Sharadamba PU College at Tikota town of Vijayapura district, where candidates objected to differences between the serial numbers printed on their OMR sheets and question papers. Several candidates walked out of the examination hall. Officials said the centre supervisor and centre chief informed candidates about the correct procedure for filling the OMR sheets. Similar confusion was reported at some other locations but did not disrupt the examinations. At the Tikota centre, candidates gathered outside after leaving the hall and later attempted to enter the premises again. Police intervened after candidates alleged they tried to pass through the gate, officials said.

KUNAL KAMRA CANCELS SHOWS AMID OPPN FROM HINDUTVA OUTFITS

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BENGALURU: Stand-up comedian Kunal Kamra has cancelled his scheduled shows in Whitefield following strong opposition from members of right-wing Hindutva groups, police said on Monday.

He personally visited the Whitefield police station on Sunday and informed the authorities that he would not go ahead with his scheduled shows in Whitefield. "He (Kamra) came to the police station and informed that he has decided to cancel the event scheduled in Whitefield due to the opposition by Hindutva activists," a senior police officer said. The development comes after the Hindu Rashtra Sena (HRS) Samiti recently submitted a petition to Bengaluru Police to cancel Kamra's stand-up performance scheduled for August 3 at URU Whitefield, citing threats to law and order and religious harmony. They contended that Kamra had disrespected Hindu deities. Kamra in a post on X said the shows for Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday were shifted to a venue in Koramangala. He also informed that BookMyShow platform would process a refund for tickets purchased.

SOUTH REGION

Insoon fury continues in Kerala, toll jumps to 15

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The death toll in rain-related incidents in Kerala rose to 15 on Monday, with several parts of the state continuing to report severe waterlogging, flash floods and landslides in high-range areas.

Chief Minister V D Satheesan convened meetings with top disaster management and revenue officials, district collectors and cabinet ministers in Thiruvananthapuram to oversee the situation. He later told reporters that while floods in some parts of the state, particularly Alappuzha and Pannathammal districts, had not receded as expected, the situation remained under control.

Till evening on Sunday, there were no predictions of extreme rain by IMD. But at night, there was extreme rainfall. In some areas, like Vadaseran in Pannathammal district, rainfall of 350 mm was recorded in the span of a few hours. Such extreme rainfall has triggered scores of landslides in deep forests, leading to



Rescue personnel evacuate residents from a flooded neighbourhood in an inflatable boat following heavy rains in Kakkodi, Kerala on Monday.

flash floods and floodwaters entering towns and villages," Satheesan told reporters at a briefing.

He dismissed media reports and widespread social media campaigns claiming that water released from dam catchment areas had caused the flood-like situation.

"Such campaigns are false. There's a lot of fake news on social media. Water levels in all major dams like Idukki, Idamalur, Kakki, Kallada, Banasur-

agar, Malamuzha and Peethi are within limits. Only excess water from the Moolozhy dam, which is a small reservoir, was released as per protocols," he said.

Two helicopters from the Indian Air Force (IAF) base in Sullur have reached Thiruvananthapuram for rescue operations, while NDRF teams from Arakkulam have been sought for relief operations, the CM said.

Additionally, 18 boats belong- ing to fisherfolk from Kollam

have been deployed in parts of Pannathammal and Alappuzha. Apart from the 15 people killed in rain-related incidents so far, seven others have been reported missing. A total of 11,018 people are currently housed in 316 relief camps across the state.

Preliminary reports indicate that 165 hectares of crops have been destroyed and 3,596 farmers affected by the extreme rains.

The Kerala CM said 88 lakh in grain relief would be distributed to the families of the deceased.

An additional 10,000 assistance would be provided for conducting the last rites of the deceased.

Families whose homes have been flooded and who have been admitted to relief camps would also receive ₹10,000 as financial assistance, he said.

With more rain predicted over parts of the state on Tuesday, a holiday for educational institutions has been declared in six districts. Public Service Commission (PSC) exams scheduled for Tuesday have also been deferred.

T'gana fast-tracks ₹84k-cr PRIL works

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HYDERABAD: Telangana Irrigation Minister N Uttam Kumar Reddy on Monday directed department officials to launch a time-bound strategy to secure statutory approval for the ₹84,000 crore Palamuru-Bangareddy Lift Irrigation Scheme (PRILS) on the Krishna river, following the latest Supreme Court judgment.

Last week, the Supreme Court upheld the validity of environmental clearances already granted by PRILS. The Seethamma Sagar multipurpose project and Gourevalli reservoir, removing a key legal hurdle to their execution.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joyyamma Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi struck down the Centre's 2021 official memorandum (OM), issued by the Union environment and forests ministry, making fresh clearances mandatory for the projects.

The bench held that environmental clearances already granted would continue to remain legally valid and clarified that completed projects need not seek fresh clearances to be affected.

Chairing a high-level review meeting on Monday, Uttam Kumar Reddy directed officials to adopt a focused approach to obtain pending environmental clearances and other statutory



N Uttam Kumar Reddy

approvals from the Centre.

The minister described the Supreme Court judgment as a landmark ruling with far-reaching implications for infrastructure and irrigation projects across the country. He said the verdict followed Telangana's sustained legal efforts to protect the interests of its irrigation projects and offered a clear legal framework for pursuing environmental approvals. He instructed officials not to lose the momentum created by the judgement and to immediately pursue every eligible case before the Centre.

On January 3 this year, the Telangana state assembly unanimously adopted a resolution requiring the Centre to grant all permissions without further delay to PRILS, which aims to utilise 90 TMC of Krishna water to meet the region's drinking water and irrigation requirements.

Chief minister A Revanth

Reddy told the assembly that the project, initiated in 2015, had failed to make major progress due to a lack of environmental and hydrological clearances from the Centre. As a result, project estimates and construction costs escalated sharply from the original ₹35,000 crore to ₹84,000 crore.

During the review meeting, the irrigation minister said environmental litigation had become increasingly complex. He asked department authorities to strengthen the inter-state wing by inducing experts in environmental regulation, engineering and legal affairs.

The expanded team would coordinate with the Union Government, the National Green Tribunal (NGT), the Supreme Court and other statutory bodies to safeguard Telangana's interests," he said.

Under the roadmap, nodal officers must be appointed for each project and all available records consolidated within seven days. Updated environmental impact studies, compliance reports, land records and legal documentation are to be completed within 30 days, while administrative processing and submission of applications should be completed within 60 days. "The state government aims to obtain project-specific environmental clearances within six months wherever feasible, subject to statutory procedures," he added.

CM VIJAY INSPECTS SAINT-GOBAIN, RENAULT PLANTS IN KANCHEEPURAM

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay on Monday visited neighbouring Kancheepuram district to inspect the Saint-Gobain float glass manufacturing unit and Renault's automobile manufacturing plant, the state government said.

Accompanied by industries minister and cabinet colleague S Keerthana and senior government officials, Vijay first visited Saint-Gobain's glass manufacturing plant at Sripurambudur, one of the region's major industrial corridors.

Located at the State Industries Promotion Corporation of Tamil Nadu (SIPCO) Industrial Park, the facility is described as Asia's largest integrated glass manufacturing plant. Vijay held discussions with senior Saint-Gobain India officials and enquired about the production of float, coated, laminated, fire-resistant and high-security glass at the facility. After observing the robotic handling area, a glass products showroom, and a glass processing unit, the chief minister interacted with students enrolled in Saint-Gobain's "Learn While Earn" initiative, which provides education and employment opportunities to underprivileged students.

Vijay also enquired about opportunities for the students (DMK) visited neighbouring Kancheepuram district to secure employment with the company.

Kerala HC grants bail to 9 CPI(M) activists in May 27 ED attack case

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Kerala High Court on Monday granted bail to nine CPI(M) activists arrested in connection with the attack on vehicles carrying Enforcement Directorate (ED) officials outside the residence of former chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan in Thiruvananthapuram on May 27.

Justice Kausar Edappagari noted that the allegations against the accused were serious, they had been in custody for two months and had no criminal antecedents.

"None of the applicants have criminal antecedents involving any serious offences. No serious injuries were sustained by the victims. For these reasons, I do not find any reason to hold that the continued detention of the

applicants is required for any purpose. Hence, the applicants are entitled to be released on bail," the judge noted in the order.

The special public prosecutor told the court that the investigation was almost complete and recovery had been effected. The HC directed the petitioners to cooperate with the investigation, deposit ₹10,000 before the magistrate court and refrain from contacting any prosecution witness.

The accused granted bail were identified as Kisan PS, Jeevan, Anil Kumar, Sheefik, Nishad, Siddharth, Sheela, Nandu GR and Rafeeq.

The accused had approached the HC after their bail pleas were dismissed by the Thiruvananthapuram district sessions court on July 21.

The incident took place on

May 27 when ED officials were conducting searches at the rented residence of Vijayan and his daughter Veena in connection with the CRRIL-Edo case. After the search ended, vehicles carrying the officials were stopped at Bakery Junction by around 300 identifiable people, mostly CPI(M) sympathisers and activists.

According to the prosecution, the accused, along with others, hurled stones at the vehicles, used obscene language and attempted to kill the officials and the driver. Police and CRPF personnel trying to remove the accused from the spot were also injured in the melee.

The accused have been booked under various sections relating to wrongful restraint, unlawful assembly, rioting, criminal assault and attempt to murder.



Udhayanidhi Stalin

UDHAYANIDHI FACES FLAK OVER REMARK ALLUDING TO ACTOR TRISHA

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THANJAVUR: Leader of Opposition in Tamil Nadu Assembly, Udhayanidhi Stalin courted controversy on Monday over his offensive remark, alluding to well-known Tamil actor Trisha.

While addressing a protest gathering over the Cauvery dispute here, Udhayanidhi told a swipe at Chief Minister Joseph Narayan. "Thirupathi said Udhayanidhi Stalin courted controversy on Monday over his offensive remark, alluding to well-known Tamil actor Trisha. While addressing a protest gathering over the Cauvery dispute here, Udhayanidhi told a swipe at Chief Minister Joseph Narayan. "Thirupathi said Udhayanidhi Stalin courted controversy on Monday over his offensive remark, alluding to well-known Tamil actor Trisha. While addressing a protest gathering over the Cauvery dispute here, Udhayanidhi told a swipe at Chief Minister Joseph Narayan. "Thirupathi said Udhayanidhi Stalin courted controversy on Monday over his offensive remark, alluding to well-known Tamil actor Trisha. While addressing a protest gathering over the Cauvery dispute here, Udhayanidhi told a swipe at Chief Minister Joseph Narayan. 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Context extends protection in under-crueity law to live-in partner

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday ruled that a man in a live-in relationship that is "in the nature of marriage" can be prosecuted for the offence of cruelty towards a woman, holding that excluding such women from the ambit of the penal law merely because they were not formally married would amount to discrimination.

In a judgment that significantly expands the reach of India's law criminalising cruelty by a husband or his relatives towards a woman, a bench of Justices Sanjay K. L. Nariman and J. K. Puri held that although Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code (IPC) uses the expression "husband", the provision cannot be interpreted so narrowly as to deprive women in marriage-like relationships of criminal remedies against cruelty merely because the relationship was not formally solemnised.

The same evil of domestic cruelty can manifest regardless of whether the woman has a formal marriage certificate or is in a relationship that bears all the essential characteristics of marriage, reasoned the bench, holding that the law must be interpreted in a manner that advances its social purpose rather than defeats it. Section 498A of the old IPC corresponds to Section 85 and Section 86 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

The ruling marks the first authoritative pronouncement

Highlights of the verdict

Anti-cruelty law can apply to live-in relationships too. Applies only to live-in relationships "in the nature of marriage".

Domestic Violence Act not enough as civil remedies cannot replace criminal prosecution for cruelty.

No automatic arrest as Anish Kumar safeguards continue to apply.

Ruling applies only to the offence of cruelty under Section 498A IPC.



extending the penal provision to qualifying live-in relationships, while making it clear that the protection is not available to every romantic relationship or casual live-in arrangement.

The court stressed that only those relationships which satisfy the judicially evolved test of being "in the nature of marriage", coupled with evidence that both parties intended to marry, would attract Section 498A. The initial burden of establishing such intent would be on the woman invoking the provision.

The judgment came while deciding an appeal arising out of Karnataka, where criminal proceedings alleging cruelty were challenged on the ground that the parties had never formally married.

Advocate Nima R Nariman assisted the court as amicus curiae

while senior counsel Anand Sanjay M Nall represented the husband in the matter.

The verdict is notable for its extensive discussion on statutory interpretation, with the bench rejecting a rigid literal reading of the penal provision in favour of a purposive construction.

"Tracing the legislative object behind Section 498A, the court said that Parliament intended the offence to combat the pervasive social evil of cruelty inflicted upon women in domestic relationships. Restricting the provision solely to legally wedded wedded, despite recognising marriage-like relationships in other branches of law, would frustrate that objective and create an artificial distinction between similarly situated women."

The bench acknowledged the settled principle that public statu-

tes are ordinarily construed strictly. However, it held that strict interpretation cannot become an instrument to defeat the very purpose for which a law was enacted. Drawing upon a line of earlier decisions, the bench said that the law has progressively recognised that certain live-in relationships deserve legal protection because they mirror the rights, obligations and vulnerabilities associated with marriage.

The Union government had argued that women in live-in relationships already have adequate protection under the Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act, 2005, making it unnecessary to extend Section 498A.

The Supreme Court rejected that contention. It held that the two enactments operate in distinct fields and serve different objectives. While the Domestic Violence Act primarily provides civil remedies such as protection orders, residence rights, maintenance and compensation, Section 498A creates criminal liability for acts of cruelty.

The availability of civil remedies, the bench said, cannot mechanically avert an accused married because an FIR has been registered. They must undertake a proper preliminary assessment, satisfy themselves that the statutory provisions are not being complied with the safeguards governing arrest under the Code of Criminal Procedure before depriving a person of liberty.

The court clarified that its ruling is confined to Section 498A and should not automatically be extended to other penal provisions where different statutory language or legislative intent may apply.

Even while extending the pro-

tection, the court repeatedly cautioned that not every live-in relationship would qualify. Reiterating the principles laid down in Indra Sarma judgment (2013), the bench said courts must examine several indicators, including the duration of the relationship, whether the parties shared a household, pooled financial resources, presented themselves socially as spouses, had children, and otherwise conducted themselves as a married couple. The court went a step further by holding that criminal prosecution under Section 498A would additionally require proof of a mutual intention to marry, ensuring that transient or casual relationships do not fall within the penal provision.

Mindful of longstanding concerns over misuse of Section 498A, the bench also directed that the safeguards laid down in the Arunesh Kumar judgment (2014) would continue to apply in full force. Police officers, it said, cannot mechanically arrest an accused married because an FIR has been registered. They must undertake a proper preliminary assessment, satisfy themselves that the statutory provisions are not being complied with the safeguards governing arrest under the Code of Criminal Procedure before depriving a person of liberty.

The court clarified that its ruling is confined to Section 498A and should not automatically be extended to other penal provisions where different statutory language or legislative intent may apply.

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NEW DELHI: The Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) setbacks in the New Delhi and Datta bypolls was the outcome of several factors, including disenchantment among upper castes, anger over paper leaks, donation theft at the Ram Temple, and intra-party issues at the local level, said several party leaders on Monday.

Bankipur was earlier held by party chief Nitin Nambhavi who vacated it following his election to the Rajya Sabha earlier this year. Both Bankipur and Datta were counted as party strongholds.

Jan Suraj Party's Prashant Kishor wrested Bankipur from the BJP, and Congress's Kuntal Ghanashyam Singh retained the seat for party. Before 2022, Datta had elected the BJP three times in a row. "The loss is an eye opener for the party... It shows how support from groups that are counted as BJP vote banks has eroded. The fact that the party did not even win in blocs where strong leaders such as Ravi Shankar Prasad, Nitin Nambhavi and Ramkripal Yadav come in is telling," said a senior party leader. In Bankipur, the BJP pulled out all the stops to win the seat that has over 42% upper caste voters, allies Lok Sabha Party and Janata Dal United also spared no effort.

But Monday's result showed that no caste bloc consolidated behind BJP candidate Neeraj Kumar. "There is a fracture in every caste group. The Kurmis are upset over Nitish Kumar being replaced by CM by Sanjay Choudhary, allies Lok Sabha Party Prashant Kishor, the Muslims do not vote for us, and only the Dalit vote seems intact. What is more worrying is that women voters seem to



Jan Suraj Party (JSP) founder Prashant Kishor after he took a lead in the Bankipur bypoll.

have drifted away too," said a second party leader. The second leader quoted above said the impact of the recent student protests could not be dismissed.

There were many caste tensions in Bankipur, and overall the number of students appearing for competitive examinations who are from Bihar is high. The issue has a strong resonance on the ground," the second leader said.

The first leader attributed the disenchantment of upper caste to issues such as the now-withdrawn UGC guidelines to set up dedicated equality committees and equity squads to address complaints about caste-based discrimination, and the appointment of Samrat Choudhary as CM.

"Other than the Kurmis who have been an important factor in Nitish Kumar's win, the U.C. largely seem as educated and informed were not happy with the choice of Choudhary as CM... then came the UGC equity regulations (later stayed by the Supreme Court) which added fuel to the fire and added to their resentment," said the first functionary.

He said statements by some leaders intended to reflect the party's stance on caste inequality were "perceived as arrogant" and alienated the urban electorate. "There were many lapses that began from picking the wrong

candidates. The first candidate Abhishek Kumar Sinha's name was withdrawn after the Opposition was all set to make his party leader Narayan Mishra overlooked for the ticket. Although he lost the 2023 polls, Mishra had won the seat three times starting 2008.

"The loss in Datta however is not because of the candidate. Even if Mishra had been fielded the party would have still lost because the U.C. is alienated," said a MP leader.

The leader explained that the Kushiwaha vote bank rallied behind the Congress candidate after the wife of murdered BJP leader K. K. Kushiwaha allegedly accused CM Mahan Yadav of "shielding the accused who was also a Yadav". There is a difference between support for the self and support for the party... because he [Mishra] had not strengthened the party, the BJP candidate did not win. The leadership had taken note of this," the leader from Mirzapur said.

In a post on X Nitin Nambhavi said, the BJP accepts the mandate and will inspect the reasons for the defeat. "We express our heartfelt gratitude to the people of Manikpur... for expressing their faith in the BJP. In Bankipur and Datta, we did not receive the expected mandate. We will conduct a thorough introspection of the election results in both these areas with complete seriousness, and with renewed energy and determination, we will continue to go among the people and work tirelessly to further strengthen their trust."

Dipke: I will show my scholarship letter if PM Modi shows his degree

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MUMBAI: Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke on Monday said he is ready to show his scholarship and loan sanction letters for his US education if Prime Minister Narendra Modi shows his degree public.

A student of HT and PTI Dipke sought a probe into the finances of Dipke's father, a retired government employee who sent his son abroad for education.

"I am ready to disclose my scholarship letter and education loan along with my degree. PM Modi should show his degree and make it public. If he does so, I am ready to make my documents public," Dipke said. "Whenever people raise their voice against this government, they start sending the ED and CBI. Let them come to my home and investigate. I am ready to show my letters, but if the PM is sending ED, he should also send his degree and make it public," he said. "My degree is authentic and I expect that Modi's degree will also be authentic," he added.

To a query on whether CJP will become a political party, Dipke said, "We don't have any such intention (of forming a political party) as of now."



Abhijeet Dipke

Nishikant seeks Zuckerberg's apology over PM reel removal

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NEW DELHI: The chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Communications and Information Technology, Nishikant Dubey, on Monday said Meta chief executive Mark Zuckerberg should apologise for the temporary removal of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Facebook reel, stating that the company could otherwise lose the "safe harbour" protection available to intermediaries under Section 79 of the Information Technology (IT) Act.

The remarks came during a meeting attended by senior officials from Meta, Google, YouTube, X and Snapchat, along with representatives of the ministry of electronics and information technology (MeitY) and the ministry of home affairs (MHA). The meeting followed Meta's brief removal of Modi's Facebook reel, prompting the government to seek an explanation.

Meta's mindset is to destabilise the country, PM Modi's video was taken down from 12:30 am to 5 am. This is a very serious issue. Our committee has said two things—the apology, attributing the removal to an algorithmic error. "An executive of Meta apologised for taking down PM Modi's video from



The meeting was chaired by BJP MP Nishikant Dubey on Monday.

Facebook. He said there was some algorithm mistake. He also assured next time it won't be repeated and that Meta will amend their algorithm," one MP said. Meta did not respond to HT's request for comment.

Opposition MPs, however, opposed any move to revoke Meta's safe harbour protection. While supporting stronger regulation to curb child sexual abuse, all parties agreed that the government should not be treated as anti-national content. "We are talking about regulating technology and not democracy. This is regulation and not censorship," an Opposition MP said, adding that the government should not target the student protests as anti-national and blamed social media algorithms for amplifying them.

According to MPs present at the meeting, Meta apologised, attributing the removal to an algorithmic error. "An executive of Meta apologised for taking down PM Modi's video from

RSS chief to interact with GenZ, Gen Alpha

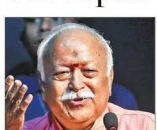
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MUMBAI: Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) leader Mohan Bhagwat is set to interact with Gen Z and Gen Alpha at the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre (NMACC) in Mumbai on August 6. The event will mark the 15th anniversary of the International Movement to Unite Nations (IIMUN) and the opening ceremony of its Annual Championship Conference.

According to the release, more than 2,000 students aged between 15 and 19 years from over 100 countries are expected to participate in the event. The participants will represent schools and colleges and will take part in discussions on global, national and international issues during the conference.

The inaugural session will be based on the theme, "The Role of Youth in Uniting the World, with thousands of civic and community activities led by young people. Now in its 15th year, IIMUN said its programmes have reached 275 cities in India and 40 countries, working with more than 150,000 schools and colleges and engaging over 75 million young people. Over the years, it has hosted several heads of state, Nobel laureates and other distinguished personalities at its events.

Rishabh Shah, founder of IIMUN, said, "Leadership is not only about guiding the next generation, but also listening to it



Mohan Bhagwat

At this critical juncture in India's journey, we need this dialogue more than ever before."

Founded in 2001, IIMUN is a youth-led public affairs platform aimed to encourage leadership, civic participation and dialogue among students. The organisation conducts 108 conferences every year along with thousands of civic and community activities led by young people. Now in its 15th year, IIMUN said its programmes have reached 275 cities in India and 40 countries, working with more than 150,000 schools and colleges and engaging over 75 million young people. Over the years, it has hosted several heads of state, Nobel laureates and other distinguished personalities at its events.

A MONTH AFTER UGC-NET, RESULTS STILL AWAITED

NEW DELHI: More than a month after the June 2026 University Grants Commission-National Eligibility Test (UGC-NET) concluded, the National Testing Agency (NTA) has yet to release either the provisional answer keys or the results.

UGC-NET, conducted twice a year in computer-based mode, disallows candidates to apply for admission to PhD programmes, recruitment as assistant professors, and the award of Junior Research Fellowships (JRF). The last session was held from June 22 to June 30 across 87 subjects.

Candidates have repeatedly urged the agency to publish the provisional answer keys before announcing the results. The answer keys enable students to verify their responses, estimate their scores and, if necessary, challenge any discrepancies before the results are prepared based on final answer keys.

The delay is significantly impacting the career prospects of students. In 2025, the June session was conducted between June 25 and June 29, while the provisional answer keys were released on July 1.

Neither NTA nor Union education ministry responded to HT's queries. **HTC**

C.I.D. RAIDS ACROSS J'KHAND OVER JSPC IRREGULARITIES

RANCHI: The Criminal Investigation Department (CID) of the Jharkhand Police on Monday conducted simultaneous raids at 18 locations as part of its probe into alleged irregularities in various competitive examinations conducted by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JSPC), officials aware of the matter said.

During the raids—conducted in various districts including Ranchi, Palamu, Hazaribagh, Bokaro, and Dhanbad—the investigation team seized a large quantity of crucial documents and electronic devices. The investigation has also revealed that the accused, Abhay Tiwari, participated in numerous competitive examinations between 2013 and 2018.

In a parallel development, former JSPC chairman and state chief secretary I. Khatri was interrogated for the fourth day on Monday at CID headquarters. "Questioning continued for several hours today. Officials conducted a detailed question-and-answer session regarding the recruitment process, selection decisions, and other key aspects. CID officials are close to the matter said."

{ MONSOON SESSION }

Govt tables ISI bill in LS to reform institute

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NEW DELHI: The government introduced the Indian Statistical Institute (ISI) Bill, 2026 in the Lok Sabha on Monday, proposing to repeal the 1959 ISI law and replace it with a new legislative framework to reform the institute's society-based governance structure with a statutory framework centred on a government-accountable Board of Governors (BoG).

The government said the legislation would modernise the institute and enable it to emerge as a globally recognised centre for statistical sciences and allied disciplines. However, sections of the ISI faculty, students and staff have opposed the move, arguing that it would dilute the institute's autonomy by centralising decision-making through BoG and increasing the Centre's control over academic and administrative affairs. A CPI(M) MP has also sought the bill's scrutiny by a House panel.

Introducing the bill, minister of state for statistics and programme implementation Rao Indrajit Singh said it seeks to provide a "comprehensive stat-

utory framework" to enable ISI to "excel as a globally recognised centre in statistical sciences and allied fields."

Under the existing legal framework, ISI is an Institution of National Importance under the ISI Act, 1959, but is administered through the ISI Society, which is registered under the West Bengal Societies Registration Act, 1961. The proposed legislation repeals the 1959 law and converts ISI into a statutory body corporate governed by a BoG. The bill proposes that ISI would be incorporated as a registered society.

Opposing the bill, faculty members along with students and non-teaching staff held a protest march at ISI headquarters in Kolkata on Monday.

Kharge accuses Modi, Shah of 'insulting' Parl

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NEW DELHI: Congress president and Rajya Sabha Leader of Opposition Mallikarjun Kharge on Monday accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah of "wilfully insulting" Parliament by staying away from its programmes as Opposition parties continued to disrupt both Houses over the alleged Ram Mandir donation theft and sought Shah's accountability over the violence against students in Delhi.

The Opposition parties have also decided to oppose the bill The Indian Statistical Institute Bill, 2026 as they allege that the Union government wants to interfere in the day to day matters and minimise the autonomy of the institute. Addressing the media, Kharge said Modi and Shah must explain the alleged donation theft at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya and the violence against students on July 20. "By abstaining from Parliament, Modi and Shah are insulting not only the institution and its members but also the people who elected them," he said.

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ROHTAK: The dusty villages of Haryana's Bhiwani district known for their renowned sex ratio and celebrated as India's "mini Cuba" for producing champion boxers, have once again reaffirmed their status as the country's boxing capital.

At the recently concluded Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, Bhiwani produced five of India's seven boxing gold medalists, including four women. The feat is particularly striking for a district that recorded a sex ratio at birth of 841 girls for every 1,000 boys till May 2025. Yet Bhiwani has repeatedly defied social stereotypes, producing generations of elite women athletes alongside some of India's finest boxers.

The district's four women champions—Sakshi Chaudhary (57kg), Preeti Pawar (54kg), Jaisimee Lamboria (57kg) and Priya Singh (54kg)—completed a clean sweep in their categories. Sachin Sivach added the fifth gold for Bhiwani by winning the men's 60kg title.

Rishabh Shah, founder of IIMUN, said, "Leadership is not only about guiding the next generation, but also listening to it

Gold medalist Sakshi Chaudhary being felicitated by UGA President PT Usha in Glasgow on Saturday.

Ankush Panghal won gold in the men's 60kg category, while Narendar Bernal claimed silver in the men's 56kg event. Women's discus throw bronze medalist Seema Kalraman is also married into a family in Bhiwani.

Overall, Haryana athletes won 11 medals, including seven golds, leading India finish fourth. Ankush Panghal won gold in the men's 60kg category, while Narendar Bernal claimed silver in the men's 56kg event. Women's discus throw bronze medalist Seema Kalraman is also married into a family in Bhiwani.

national champion, she became the first Indian woman to win a World Boxing Cup gold last year before adding Commonwealth gold to her collection.

Another boxer, 23-year-old Preeti Pawar of Badliwala village, gave India its first boxing gold of the Games by winning the women's 54kg title. The daughter of Haryana Police assistant sub-inspector Somnath Pawar, she took up boxing at 14 on her father's encouragement.

Jaisimee Lamboria, 25, a Naib Subedar in the Army, captured the women's 57kg title to add to her 2025 World Championship and World Boxing Cup triumphs. A 2024 Olympian, she overcame initial opposition from her father, Home Guard personnel Jaibir Lamboria, to pursue boxing. Coming from a family of doctors, she has established herself among India's leading women pugilists.

Dhanana village celebrated again as Priya Singh struck gold in the women's 60kg category. The daughter of businessman Mahender Ghanghars, she began boxing at 16 before joining the Sports Authority of India training centre in Bhiwani.

Bhiwani's lone male gold medalist, Sachin Sivach of Mithal village, dominated the men's 60kg category. A former Youth World champion and silver medalist at the Captain Hovda Singh Boxing Academy, initially considered too weak for the sport, he overcame the odds with the support of his mother, Mrs. Sushila Sivach, and won Pawan Sivach.

Nineteen-year-old Ankush Panghal from Hissar announced himself on the world stage by defeating England's Dineen Shittu for the men's 60kg gold, while Narendar Bernal of Sorli village in Hansi secured silver in the heavyweight division.

DKS expands cabinet, inducts 19

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BENGALURU: Karnataka's long-awaited cabinet expansion took shape on Monday with the induction of 19 ministers, bringing the strength of the chief minister DK Shivakumar-led council of ministers to 33, even as the cabinet continues to have no women's representation. Meanwhile, a Congress MLA submitted his resignation from the legislative post while another threatened to follow suit after being left out.



DK Shivakumar in a group photograph with newly inducted ministers at Raj Bhavan on Monday. ANI

leader, was kept out after former CM Siddaramaiah raised concerns about not being consulted on the appointment. Shivakumar was sworn-in as the CM along with 13 ministers on June 3, following Siddaramaiah's resignation on May 28. After the expansion, the cabinet now has one vacant berth. Among the first-time ministers inducted on Monday are Mayakonda MLA KS Basavanthappa, T Raghunurthy (Challakere), Hiran Arshad (Shivajinagar), Ajay Singh (Jevargi), K M Shivalinge Gowda (Arasikere), HC Balakrishna (Maggadi), and Vijayanand

Kashappanavar (Bagalokote). Those who were part of the earlier Siddaramaiah-led cabinet include Shivang Tangadagi (Kanakagiri), B Nagendra (Ballari rural), BZ Zameer Ahmed Khan (Chamarajpet), Santosh Lad (Kalgathagi), and N Chaturvaraya Swamy (Nagamangala). The expansion maintained the social balance with seven ministers each sworn in from the Lingayat and Scheduled Caste, Vokkaligas hold five positions, Muslim representation has also grown from two ministers to three. B Nagendra (ST), who had resigned from former chief minis-

ter Siddaramaiah's cabinet after his name surfaced in the multi-crore financial scam in Valmiki Development Corporation, has made a comeback. The expansion, however, left several Congress legislators dissatisfied. Indi MLA Vishwanatharao V Patil submitted his resignation from his legislative post after missing out on a cabinet berth, while Sagar MLU Debur Gopalakrishna announced he would also resign. HC Mahadevappa, HK Patil, Dinesh Gundu Rao, K Venkatesh, MC Sudhakar and Laxmi Hebballur were among the other notable senior Congress leaders

left out of the cabinet. "It is disappointing that after so many years of service to the state and the party, I have not been considered to serve the government in this cabinet. I am disappointed by decisions taken without being given any reason for my exclusion," Gundu Rao said on X. Senior Congress leader Margaret Alva also voiced concern over the composition of the cabinet, expressing disappointment over no women representation. "I would have loved to see at least one Congress woman in the new Karnataka Cabinet sworn in today. Deeply disappointed that there isn't one," she said in a post on X. BJP state chief BY Vijayendra questioned the Congress over women's representation in the cabinet. "The people will teach a fitting lesson in the coming days to this government that opposes women and fosters corruption," he said in a post on X. Responding to the criticism, Shivakumar said, "Let them (BJP) wait; there are a lot of vacancies. Last time, too, there were no women in the first round. We are all there."

TN moves top court to enforce Cauvery water release order

Ayesha Arvind
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BENGALURU: The Tamil Nadu government on Monday moved the Supreme Court seeking directions to Karnataka to immediately implement the would have loved to see at least one Congress woman in the new Karnataka Cabinet sworn in today. Deeply disappointed that there isn't one," she said in a post on X. BJP state chief BY Vijayendra questioned the Congress over women's representation in the cabinet. "The people will teach a fitting lesson in the coming days to this government that opposes women and fosters corruption," he said in a post on X. Responding to the criticism, Shivakumar said, "Let them (BJP) wait; there are a lot of vacancies. Last time, too, there were no women in the first round. We are all there."

THE STATE SOUGHT DIRECTION TO KARNATAKA TO COMPENSATE FOR THE SHORTFALL OF RELEASE FROM JUNE 1 TO AUGUST 12

that even if Karnataka were to fully comply with the CWMA's direction, it would receive only 4,536 TMC of water, leaving a backlog of 5,379 TMC even under the distress-sharing formula adopted by the authority. According to the state, if the inflows into Karnataka's four major reservoirs up to August 3 are assessed against the 30-year average, the pro-rata distress ratio works out to 46.34%, under which Karnataka ought to have ensured releases of 26,954 TMC between June 1 and August 12.

"The direction given by the CWRC and CWMA is only 4,536 TMC, which is far less than the quantum of water as per distress proportion," the application stated. Tamil Nadu further alleged that Karnataka had not complied even with the limited direction issued by the authority. It pointed out that actual flows recorded at Billigundlu between July 29 and August 2 ranged only between 158 cusecs and 530 cusecs, far below the mandated 3,500 cusecs. "It is evident that Karnataka has wilfully not complied with the directions of the CWRC/CWMA," the application said.

The state submitted that as on August 3, Karnataka had gross storage of 77,537 TMC across its four principal reservoirs — 23,078 TMC in KRS, 18,610 TMC in Kabini, 7,827 TMC in Harangi and 28,022 TMC in Hemavathy.



Udhayanidhi Stalin
UDHAYANIDHI FACES FLAK OVER REMARK ALLUDING TO TRISHA

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THANJAVUR: Tamil Nadu leader of opposition of Tamil Nadu assembly Udhayanidhi Stalin courted controversy on Monday over his offensive remark, alluding to well-known Tamil actor Trisha.

While addressing a protest gathering over the Cauvery dispute in Thanjavur, Udhayanidhi took a swipe at Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, alleging that Tamil Nadu had not received a single drop of Cauvery water while the CM remained unconcerned. The rally took a controversial turn when someone in the crowd chanted, "Trisha, Trisha".

Pausing his speech, Udhayanidhi, with a smirk on his face, responded with an offensive double entendre, a remark that has since sparked severe political backlash.

Taking to X, Tamil Nadu BJP chief spokesperson Narayanan Thirupathy said Udhayanidhi's "double-meaning" remark is "disgusting, obscene, vulgar and shameful".

"Truly, even a rogue or thief who has a mother, wife, daughter would not speak so vulgarly. No mother, wife, or daughter would forgive those who speak like that," wrote the BJP leader. According to him, Udhayanidhi should be arrested and imprisoned for this comment. "Arresting and imprisoning Udhayanidhi Stalin for this low-grade speech would bring more credit to Tamil Nadu Chief Minister than arresting Markandeyan (DMK MLA), Thirupathy said.

MINOR AMONG 3 HELD IN ASSAM RAPE-MURDER CASE

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SILCHAR: Assam Police on Monday arrested two men, aged 18 and 19, and detained a 17-year-old for raping and brutally murdering a 16-year-old girl in Hailakandi district, police said. They said that the accused and the victim knew each other and that "there was communication" between them.

"One of the accused is 17 and a half years old but considering the brutality of the case, we have appealed to the court to try him as an adult," said the Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP), Hailakandi, Anilab Sinha. Additional superintendent of police, Hailakandi, Samir Dapur Baruah said that the three accused have been booked under relevant sections of BNS and POCSO Act.

SSP Sinha said that the motive behind the murder is yet to be ascertained but initial probe revealed that the accused knew the victim and everything about her house.

"They knew where to go and when to go. There were communications between the girl and the boys and we are investigating this further. However, we cannot come to any quick conclusion, we can only say that a thorough investigation is happening," he added.



Pema Khandu
SC SUMMONS TOP ARUNACHAL GOVT OFFICIALS IN PROBE AGAINST KHANDU

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday summoned the chief secretary and principal secretary (home) of the Arunachal Pradesh government, expressing strong displeasure over what it described as the state's non-cooperation with a court-monitored CBI probe into allegations that chief minister Pema Khandu favoured firms linked to his family in the award of government contracts.

A bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta directed both officers to remain personally present on August 24 and explain why the state had failed to cooperate with the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) despite specific directions issued by the court in April. "We have perused CBI's status report dated July 17, it reflects that there is non-cooperation at the end of the state government, as directed by this court on April 6. As such we deem it appropriate to issue notice to the chief secretary and principal secretary (home), Government of Arunachal Pradesh," the bench said in its order. The court directed the two officers to appear with their responses to CBI's status report "and explain why there is non-cooperation and non-compliance with the order of this court".

The observations came after the bench questioned the lack of progress in the investigation. "Why is there non-cooperation? And what steps you from registering a case?" the bench asked CBI, referring to the preliminary enquiry directed earlier.

IT reached out to the chief minister's office but could not get a response till going to the print.

SC urges ED to let TMC use frozen funds for day-to-day functioning

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday urged the Enforcement Directorate (ED) to consider releasing some money from three debit-frozen bank accounts of the Trinamool Congress (TMC), observing that the Mamata Banerjee-led party would require funds for its day-to-day functioning and legal expenses even as the legality of the freezing order remains under challenge. A bench of justices MM Sundresh and PB Vanele asked the central agency to obtain instructions and revert after a week, while clarifying that it was not expressing

any opinion on the merits of the dispute, which is pending before the Calcutta High Court. "We have suggested both sides that some amount can be released for the administrator for daily expenses and some other necessary expenses. We clarify that we have not dealt with the merit of the case since the matter is pending before the Calcutta high court," said the SC, listing the matter next week. The observations came during the hearing of the TMC's appeal against a July 20 Calcutta HC order refusing interim relief against ED's decision to freeze three HDFC Bank accounts of the party as part of a money laundering probe. Appearing for the TMC, senior

advocates Kapil Sibal and Monika Guruswamy submitted that the party had been left "completely stifled monetarily", contending that it had no funds to pay salaries, legal expenses or meet routine organisational expenditure. Additional solicitor general SV Raju, appearing for ED, said that the order was passed before the administrator was appointed. He argued that the TMC operated several other bank accounts and was not entirely without funds. The bench, however, indicated that the agency could consider allowing access to a limited amount through the court-appointed administrator to meet essential expenses, including the legal costs.

LICENSED FIREARM CAN'T BE USED FOR 'JOY FIRING': HC

PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad high court has ruled that a licensed firearm cannot be used for "joy firing" during weddings or religious festivals, emphasising that every arms licensee is duty-bound to maintain proper records of cartridges purchased and used. Justice Saurabh Shyam Shamsery, while dismissing a petition filed by one Akhilesh Kumar, refused to interfere with the cancellation of arms licence issued to him, after the holder failed to account for 757 missing cartridges. "An arms licence being a privilege is only issued when the petitioner undertakes that strict conditions of the licence shall be complied with," justice Shamsery observed, m/c

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Govt flags concerns over gender self-identification

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NEW DELHI: The Union government on Monday told the Supreme Court that accepting the principle of self-identification of gender under the new transgender law could render 169 statutory provisions across different laws "unworkable", even as the court agreed to examine whether transgender persons issued identity cards under the previous legal regime require interim protection to continue receiving benefits already available to them.

A bench, comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, and Justices Jaymya Bagchi and V Mohana, posted the matter for August 17, when it will consider passing an interim order on protecting the rights of existing transgender card holders while the constitutional challenge to the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Act, 2026 remains pending.

The observations came during hearings in two connected matters one involving a fresh challenge to the amended law, and another concerning a batch of petitions challenging its constitutional validity, along with the Centre's plea to transfer similar cases pending before various high courts to the Supreme Court.

The 2026 amendment has been challenged by transgender activists and organisations on the ground that it dilutes the principle of self-identification recognised by the apex court in the landmark NALSA judgment.

Appearing for petitioner Anuraj M, senior advocate Anand Grover argued that the amended law had fundamentally altered the principle recognised by the court in that judgment in 2014.

"The new law has created serious problems. I might have been born as a man but in my mind and personality, I am a woman. The new law takes away that right from me," Grover submitted.

The bench agreed to issue notice in the petition and tag it with the pending batch of challenges, organisations and community leaders challenging the law.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, said the government's response would be filed in the main batch itself and cautioned against accepting an unrestricted principle of self-identification.

"I must point out that at least 169 statutory provisions across different laws will become unworkable if the argument that I am born

as a man but I should be treated as a woman is accepted," Mehta submitted.

Later, when the batch of petitions was taken up, senior advocate Jayna Kothari submitted that the amended law had already come into force on May 25 pursuant to a gazette notification and that the National Portal for Transgender Persons had become non-functional, creating immediate difficulties for the community.

She urged the court to ensure that persons who had obtained transgender identity cards under the earlier legal framework were not deprived of benefits available to them. "And those who have got the TG card under the old legal regime, they should not be denied benefits they are entitled to," Kothari argued.

Responding to the submissions, Mehta said the legislature had consciously altered the legal framework because of wider implications flowing from self-identification.

"Self-determination is one issue. Suppose a person born as a man starts using a toilet meant for women. Suppose I die, the succession would be as per Hindu male dying intestate or Hindu female dying intestate? These are issues which will have to be gone into," the solicitor general submitted.

The bench, however, indicated that rights already accrued under the previous legal regime could not be taken away without clear legislative intent.

"If the legislature felt that it was

LS PASSES BILL TO RAISE S.C. JUDGES' STRENGTH TO 38

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NEW DELHI: The Lok Sabha on Monday passed the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026, raising the sanctioned strength of judges in the top court from 34 to 38, including the Chief Justice of India. The Bill, passed by a voice vote, replaces an ordinance promulgated in May and comes amid a mounting "backlog" of cases before the court.

Union law minister Arjun Ram Meghwal introduced the Bill amid Opposition protests. The Bill states that the persistent gap between institution and disposal of cases has made "docket management" increasingly difficult, particularly for older pending matters and cases needing larger benches.

The Supreme Court's sanctioned strength has been revised several times since 1950, when the court began with eight judges, including the Chief Justice of India. It was raised to 31 in 2008 and to 34 in 2019. The government now proposes taking it to 38.

According to a written reply by Meghwal in Parliament, more than 36,000 cases are currently pending in the Supreme Court, with 26 cases unresolved for over 30 years and 558 pending for more than two decades.

The government maintains that adding judges is among the most effective ways to cut this backlog in the court.

The Bill was first introduced in the Lok Sabha on July 20, before being taken up for consideration and passage on Monday.

Kerala, Assam rains toll rises to 102; flash floods in Kashmir

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM/GUWAHATI/SRINAGAR: The death toll in rain-related incidents in Kerala rose to 15 on Monday, as several parts of the state continued to report severe waterlogging, flash floods and landslides in high-range areas.

Chief Minister V Sathesnan convened meetings in Thiruvananthapuram with top disaster management officials, revenue officials, district collectors and cabinet ministers to review the situation. He later told reporters that floodwaters in some parts of the state, especially in Alappuzha and Pathanamthitta districts, had not receded as expected, but said the situation was under control.

The death toll in Assam floods increased to 87 with two more fatalities reported while over 1.28 lakh people in seven districts remained affected by the deluge, according to an official bulletin



Security personnel stand guard near a bridge that was damaged after a cloudburst triggered flash floods in Pahalgam.

on Monday. The Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA), in its report, said both the deaths were reported from the worst-hit Sivasagar district. The seven districts still reeling under flood were Charaideo, Sivasagar, Dhemajee, Golaghat, Biswanath, Jorhat and Lakhimpur, where 380 villages and 14,230,148 hectares of crop area remained inundated.

In north Kashmir's Kupwara district, a 52-year-old woman died after a column of water swept her away as a cloudburst struck the Himli area of Lolab. Police said Naseema Begum was in an agricultural field near a small nallah when she was caught in flash floods triggered by the cloudburst.

Heavy rains lashed parts of Jammu and Kashmir, leading to the closure of the Srinagar-Jammu National Highway (NH-44) and triggering flash floods several parts of Kashmir.

Despite uptick in July rain, Kharif sowing lags

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NEW DELHI: The sowing of the monsoon crop (kharif) across India remained below last year's level despite an improvement in July rainfall, with farmers planting crops in 105.2 million hectares as of July 31, 3.6% lower than a year ago, as the delayed onset of the southwest monsoon and uneven rainfall distribution continued to weigh on planting decisions. According to experts, this is likely to impact total food output this season.

The latest agriculture ministry data show the gap has narrowed only marginally from about 5% a week ago, suggesting that while sowing has picked up after the monsoon revived in July, the recovery has been insufficient to offset the damage caused by a rain-deficient June.

The sowing shortfall comes at a time when the IMD has warned that the country is likely to receive below-normal rainfall during August and September,



As of July 31, farmers planted crops in 105.2 million hectares this kharif season.

with El Nino conditions expected to strengthen. That has heightened concerns over crop growth and yields, particularly in areas where the crops depend on rains for irrigation.

According to IMD, cumulative rainfall between June 1 and July 31 was about 13% below the long-period average. While rainfall improved in July, it remained unevenly distributed, with most of the excess precipitation concentrated over central India, particularly Odisha, Gujarat and Maharashtra. Eastern and northeastern India continued to record rainfall deficits of nearly 30%, and south India, 25%.

ART to hear plea on freezing eggs without husband's nod

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MUMBAI: The Bombay High Court has directed the National Assisted Reproductive Technology (ART) and Surrogacy Board to consider a plea filed by a Pune resident seeking permission to freeze her eggs without her husband's consent, which is required under the ART Act.

A division bench of acting chief justice Ravindra Ghuge and justice Gautam Anhad last week passed the order after additional government pleader

HC ACCEPTED THAT THE HUSBAND WAS UNLIKELY TO CONSENT TO EGG FREEZING WHILE DIVORCE PROCEEDINGS WERE UNDERWAY

levels were declining and if they fell further, she would no longer be able to bear a child. The petitioner got married in April 2016 but was allegedly sub-

jected to mental and physical cruelty, prompting her to leave her husband in June 2020. Apart from filing criminal proceedings against him, she also filed a divorce petition two months later, she submitted.

She said she began medical consultations and preparations for the egg-freezing procedure in January 2024. After her doctor advised her to freeze her eggs, she filed a plea before the family court in September 2025, seeking permission to undergo the procedure without her husband, who had refused consent unless

she withdrew all legal proceedings against him.

The petitioner contended that the statutory framework governing ART mandated spousal consent, that a woman whose marriage had irretrievably broken down and whose divorce proceedings had remained pending for several years could not be compelled to permanently lose her reproductive ability.

The bench found merit in the submission that the husband would never consent while divorce proceedings were underway and posted for August 31.

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HALF OF NEW ONGC STORAGE TO BE SET FOR STRATEGIC RESERVES: CENTRE

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NEW DELHI: Oil and Natural Gas Corp (ONGC) will reserve half of its planned 1.75 million metric ton (about 13 million barrels) oil storage facility to meet the country's strategic needs, junior oil minister Suresh Gopi told lawmakers on Monday.

Last month, the top oil explorer announced plans to build the strategic petroleum reserve at Mangaluru in Karnataka state, where its Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals subsidiary operates a refinery with capacity of 300,000 barrels per day.

Indian rules allow commercial use of a part of the existing SPR storage built at three locations — Mangaluru, Padur and Vizag — in southern India with 5.33 million tons of capacity. These storage facilities are managed by the government-owned Indian Strategic Petroleum Reserves Ltd (ISPR). MRPL has already leased half of the 1.5 million ton Mangaluru SPR.

Gopi also said India has the capacity to store crude oil and petroleum products to meet 74 days of its net crude import needs, including offshore facilities and its 35,000 km pipeline network.

India plans to build about 4 million tons of strategic storage at Chandikhol in the eastern state of Odisha and a new 2.5 million ton facility at Padur in southern India in collaboration with private companies. Gopi said ISPR has acquired the land for the Chandikhol project, which is estimated to cost ₹90 billion.

Parl panel maintains high approval rate for wildlife projects in 10 years

Jasveer Gandhiok

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NEW DELHI: Around 93% or 99 out of the 107 development and infrastructure-related projects placed before the Standing Committee of the National Board for Wildlife (SC-NBWL) were approved in its latest meeting in Coimbatore on July 9, keeping in line with a trend in recent years where approval rates for projects in wildlife reserves, sanctuaries and notified forest land remain unusually high.

Data from the minutes of meeting, the 91st of SC-NBWL, made available recently, showed that while no project was outrightly rejected, the Committee deferred four proposals, returned two back to the states — for a state-level clearance — and kept two others in abeyance, until the Supreme Court cleared them.

HT, on July 12 reported how over the last decade, since 2016, SC-NBWL approved 96.5% of development-related projects it considered.

A scrutiny of data available online showed that across the 52 meetings held since 2016, 2,448 development proposals were placed before the committee: of this 572 were deferred, and of the 1,876 considered, 1,810 were cleared and 66 rejected.

The decade-long data assessment showed consistently high approval rates. In 2018, 2021 and the first meeting of 2026, every proposal considered was approved — none were rejected. Even in 2020, when the committee recorded its lowest approval rate, it cleared 82 of the 92 pro-



Projects at SGNP was also approved in the latest meeting.

jects considered — an approval rate of about 89%.

In its latest meeting, development projects recommended by SC-NBWL for approval, span those in tiger reserves including the Biligiri Rangana Temple (BRT) tiger reserve, Palamau tiger reserve, Ranthambore, Duxa, Mukundara, Srivilliputhur Megamala, Pilibhit and Melghat; eco-sensitive zones, including the Sanjay Gandhi National Park (SGNP), Kamala Bird Sanctuary; and wildlife sanctuaries including Cauvery, Sharavathi Valley LTM, Someshwara and the Dadra & Nagar Haveli sanctuaries.

The proposals approved include using 0.234 hectares (ha) forest land from core area of BRT Tiger Reserve for providing Functional Household Tap Connections (FHTCs) to 139 households; 0.10 ha of forest land from core area of BRT tiger reserve for providing FHTCs to 146 households; 41.48 ha of forest land from the tiger corridor in Satna and Panna to establish the Panari Standalone pump Storage Project (1800 MW); using 5.32 ha including the buffer and Eco-

Sensitive Zone of Melghat Tiger Reserve for upgradation of roads; and using 18.462 hectares from Satpura-Melghat Tiger Corridor for construction of a railway line.

The projects cleared, included a special case, a proposal to use 2.18 hectares of forest land from Kumbhalakonda Wildlife Sanctuary for a road connecting to National Highway-16.

"The Standing Committee observed that the proposed road is a new road running along the periphery of Kumbhalakonda Wildlife Sanctuary and noted that, as a general principle, construction of new roads within a wildlife sanctuary is not permissible. However, considering the peripheral location of road and the larger public interest involved, the committee decided to recommend the proposal as a special case," the minutes state.

The functioning of both the National Board of Wildlife (NBWL) and its standing committee has come under criticism by experts, with a petition filed before the Delhi High Court by 10 conservationists and activists last week claiming the SC-NBWL was "recklessly clearing projects" at a high approval rate.

In response, the high court pulled up the Centre on July 8 for "treating every statutory body as an extension of the government's arm." A bench of Chief Justice D.K. Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia sought a response from the government in four weeks' time.

"...If what the (petitioners' lawyer) says is correct, see the composition of the Board... highest level functionaries of the

country are members, and if the (Wildlife Act provisions) says Standing committee will be constituted by the Board, not the government, can't you differentiate simply between a statutory board and the functions of the government?" CJ Upadhyaya had said.

SC-NBWL is headed by the Union environment minister, with the additional director general of forests (Wildlife) as its member secretary, and also includes the secretary, environment, and the Director General of Forests & Special Secretary (DGF&SS), among other members and experts.

An environment ministry official said SC-NBWL recommends the proposals as per the section 29 of the Wildlife Act, with chief wildlife wardens having the authority to allow such projects, in consultation with the state government and SC-NBWL.

"The SC-NBWL takes a view on ecological consideration with the views of NCTA, Wildlife Institute of India and experts in the committee. The proposal falling outside the PAs in ESZ are also considered in the SC-NBWL which do not actually fall in forest area or PA most of the time," said the official, adding that the number of proposals have gone up due to an increase in infra projects across the country in the last decade.

"Therefore, the frequency and number of proposals specially related to defence proposal and proposals of linear infra such as rail, road and power lines have gone up. Thus the interpretation being made is very loose," said the official said.

Suspected kanwariyas ransack Lucknow school van, 3 booked

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LUCKNOW: Three unidentified people have been booked after a group of men, who claimed to be a part of the Kanwar Yatra, allegedly ransacked and pelted stones at a private school van, carrying seven children in Lucknow on Monday, police said.

According to police, the incident took place at the Chowk area after an argument over a minor collision between the van and the men on a bike. Police, however, did not officially mention if the accused were kanwariyas despite witnesses' allegations.

Police registered the FIR after videos on social media showed that broken window glass of the school van and schoolgirls standing on the street, and parents approached them.

THE INCIDENT TOOK PLACE AROUND 7 AM WHEN THE VAN COLLIDED WITH A BIKE CARRYING 3 UNIDENTIFIED MEN, POLICE SAID

Lucknow's deputy commissioner of police (West) Kamlesh Dixit said the three people had escaped by the time police reached the site.

According to a complaint submitted to the Chowk police by parents of Emma Thompson School, Lalbagh, the incident took place at around 7am when the van carrying children was passing through the Charak crossing under the Chowk police station limits.

"After a minor accident, mem-

bers of a Kanwariya group stopped the vehicles in front of my van and started hurling stones at the vehicle, damaging it and leaving the children terrified," said Mohammad Amir, the van driver.

In a video, the men could be seen fleeing the spot on their bike as another individual recording the video was seen chasing them away. Another video also showed a smashed window with children sitting inside.

Satendra Divvedi, a parent, said no child sustained serious injuries but maintained that the incident could have led to a tragedy. "We are filing a complaint at Chowk police station to register an FIR," said Neelima Mishra, another parent.

Zareen Khan, another parent, told the media, "This happened in front of cops. They kept mum and watched it."



280 AICTE-approved technical institutions shut in 3 years: Govt

NEW DELHI: 280 AICTE-approved technical institutions closed across India over the last three academic years from 2024-25, with Maharashtra (57), Uttar Pradesh (54), Madhya Pradesh (53) and Tamil Nadu (45) recording the highest numbers, the Centre informed the Lok Sabha on Monday.

It added that the enrolment in them increased from 2.21 million in 2023-24 to 2.96 million in 2025-26.

5 killed, 2 injured in multi-vehicle accident in Tamil Nadu

MADURAI: Five people, including a three-year-old girl, died and two others were injured in a multi-vehicle accident near Melur in this district, police said.

According to the police, the accident occurred on the Thuvampatti four-lane flyover stretch when a car carrying six people — three men, two women, and a child — en route from Chennai to Tirunelveli collided with a two-wheeler moving ahead.

Over 5,600 kg coins found at UP shop, trader booked

AGRA: 5663.3 kg of ₹1, 2, and 5-rupee coins stored in 106 plastic bags were recovered from a shop in Uttar Pradesh's Hathras and a case has been registered against Naveen Samadhi, the shopkeeper, police said on Monday.

The case was registered under Section 12 (prohibition of making or melting or destruction of coins) and 13 of the Coinage Act 2011, which provides seven years' imprisonment or a fine.

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{ OUR TAKE }

The quarrel over Cauvery

Karnataka and Tamil Nadu must enter the negotiation room with renewed dedication amid accelerating climate-crisis impacts

The leaders on either side of the divide have changed and so have the eras, but the century-old dispute between Karnataka and Tamil Nadu over sharing the water of the Cauvery simmers. This week, a potential face-off between Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar and his Tamil Nadu counterpart C Joseph Vijay was averted after the latter agreed to postpone his visit to Bengaluru. Tensions have been rising between the two neighbours amid an indifferent monsoon — the monsoon was 19% below normal in Karnataka from June 1 to August 3 and 13% below normal in Tamil Nadu — and Vijay's government has approached the Supreme Court.

The immediate trigger for the bitterness appears to be developments on the Mekedatu reservoir project, first proposed by Karnataka decades ago to solve the drinking water woes of Bengaluru. Tamil Nadu believes the project — which is planned to come up close to the site where the river enters Tamil Nadu — will adversely affect the flow of water downstream. But the enduring trigger for the dispute every year — irrespective of the party in power in either Bengaluru or Chennai — is the increasingly precarious dependence of either state on the river. This year, the flow has reduced to a trickle due to indifferent rainfall across the Cauvery basin this season. Clearly, against the backdrop of lopsided and haphazard monsoons and the climate crisis wreaking havoc with both the spatial and temporal distribution of rainfall, both states need to have worked on scientifically sound environmental plans that could augment water requirement for drinking (Bengaluru) or agricultural (Tamil Nadu) purposes.

Instead, neither state appears to have built viable strategies to mitigate the impact of the climate crisis.

Water tribunal awards aren't meant for good monsoons. Their efficacy is only visible in a deficient monsoon year, such as 2026 where the long shadow of El Nino continues to stalk rainfall projections. The Cauvery water award first took 27 years of hearing, another six for the government to announce the allocation, and a further five to establish a water management authority. In an era where skews in rainfall change by the week and the climate crisis has rendered previous models useless, such long timelines are impractical. Political brinkmanship has to exit this stage. Instead, both states need to enter the room with renewed dedication to safeguard their poorest constituents from the vagaries of a rapidly changing world.

A yatra from ritual piety to base violence

While the etymology stays contested — like most other associated things — there has been some consensus among scholars that religion comes from the Latin verb *religare*, which means 'to bind'. Ritual comes from *ritus*, which means a correct way of doing things. The roots of these words, along with their meanings and thus intent, appear forgotten when we look at some practices that are neither correct nor bind human beings, either to each other or to divinity. The annual mahayatra created by the *kanwariyas* in the states of Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, and the National Capital Territory of Delhi is one good exhibit.

As monsoon peaks in the region, so does the pilgrimage of bringing the sacred — in the form of water from the Ganga — to one's doorstep. Drops of *gangajal* are supposed to cleanse all mortal sins. So far, so good, but does it not, then, become almost blasphemous to engage in unlawful practices during this very journey? The *kanwariyas* clearly do not think so. Every year, many of these devotees, mostly young men, run amok with their entitlement to flout all laws of the land and are answerable to none. As if traffic disruptions, intolerable decibels of the DJ trucks, and littering at the pit stops aren't enough, untrammelled acts of violence against people and property have become a regular feature of the *kanwar yatra*. Extending tacit support of governments, no violation is serious enough to stir law enforcement into action, not even attacks on school buses, as happened in Lucknow on August 3. The issue here is not of policing faith but allowing people to use faith as a get-out-of-jail card.

The here and now of a 'forever war' period

As multipolarity solidifies, a new stable equilibrium could be ushered in — one in which States realise attacking others will not alter the balance of power in their favour

Although there have been several on-off announcements about negotiations, ceasefires, and deals to end the conflict between Russia and Ukraine, and between US-Israel and Iran, we are staring at a grim reality. Protracted conventional armed conflicts among countries are back in vogue, growing at an alarming rate, and proving to be intractable.

A study by the Norway-based Peace Research Institute Oslo (PRIO) finds that direct inter-State conflicts have doubled in the past few decades, jumping from two in 2023 to four in 2024, and reaching eight in 2025, which is the highest since data collection began in 1946. Comparing the current upward trajectory of inter-State wars with the Cold War era (1946-1989) and the post-Cold War era (1990-2020), it looks like humanity is going backwards, in the direction of savagery, instead of moving forward towards civilisation.

The Cold War period saw an average of two to four active inter-State

conflicts per year, headlined by the Korean War (1950-1953), the Vietnam War (1965-1973), the India-Pakistan Wars (1948, 1965 and 1971), the Arab-Israeli Wars (1948, 1956, 1967 and 1973), and the Iran-Iraq War (1980-1988). Even though civil wars or internal wars outnumbered inter-State wars, the wars between States were deadly and accounted for up to four million battle-related deaths. What made things worse was that the average duration of these inter-State wars — many were prolonged by superpower-fuelled intervention — was around 16 to 24 months.

The post-Cold War period offered a welcome respite from this dreadful dynamic. Thanks to the end of the ideological contest between capitalism and Communism and the weakening of all power centres except the US, this era saw an average of only one to two active inter-State wars per year lasting approximately three to four-and-a-half months. Fewer inter-State wars brought relief because international order rests on mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity of States. If inter-State wars lessen, it makes international institutions such as the United Nations (UN) more effective. No wonder, therefore, that the post-Cold War phase was a golden era for the UN.

But since 2020, this relatively benign phase has been replaced by a ferocious new trend of frequent and lengthy

inter-State wars that have once again marginalised the UN. The Russia-Ukraine war has exceeded four-and-a-half years of continuous fighting. The multiple wars involving Israel, Lebanon and the Palestinian Territories have dragged on for three years. And the US and Israeli war on Iran which began in 2025, ebbed for a while, and then resumed in 2026, looks open-ended with no closure. There have been some short multi-day conflicts between Armenia and Azerbaijan (2020) and between India and Pakistan (2025), but is it any one's guess whether these will reignite after a pause.

One key factor behind the sharp uptick in inter-State wars and their longevity is something that is normally viewed as a positive development — the onset of a multipolar world. With more power centres emerging, the willingness to attack directly or to sponsor proxies that can withstand aggressors as part of global geopolitical rivalries has grown. If the original Cold War era saw two superpowers that destabilised the world by arming their proxies, the current 'new Cold War' is diffused, with more players. A smaller state would not need to pay attention to a big Russia if it wasn't for both the US and Europe backing the former militarily and economically. And Iran's resistance against the much superior Israel and the US owes to the intelligence, targeting, satellite, technological, and economic backing of Russia and China.



Sreeram Chaulia



A small Ukraine would not have held on for so long against a big Russia if it wasn't for both the US and Europe backing the former.

Pakistan's propensity to carry out large-scale terrorist attacks in India, which New Delhi says would be considered 'acts of war' from now on, is also rationalised by the active military and economic support Islamabad receives from Beijing. Operation Sindoor in 2025 was relatively short but saw high-intensity war-like clashes because Pakistan was emboldened by Chinese weaponry, intelligence, economic and diplomatic sympathies. As India grows economically faster than China and is likely to reduce the power gap with China in years to come, their Asian Cold War is likely to trigger more India-Pakistan wars or mini-wars by proxy association.

Apart from complex multipolarity, the other reason why inter-State wars are growing and lasting longer is the shift in modern military technology. Stronger attackers believe they have the upper hand and initiate wars, but defensive weaponry and tactics are improving. Drones, anti-tank, anti-air and anti-aircraft missiles and counteroffensive strike capabilities have prevented easy walkovers for attackers. Presidents Vladimir Putin and Donald Trump have found that weak opponents can withstand long

invasions or aerial bombardments for years due to this change in the structure of warfare. Given these underlying structural shifts, is there no light at the end of the tunnel and are we condemned to suffer 'forever wars'? The good news is that as multipolarity solidifies, and once power transitions are completed, a new stable equilibrium could be ushered in, in which States realise it is too costly to attack other States, since attacking will not alter the balance of power in their favour. And with time, as defensive military technology advances further, it too may deter offensive States from daring to attempt invasions and regime changes. For instance, China may decide not to attack or to delay attacking Taiwan after seeing the way Ukraine and Iran warred off Russia and the US for years.

The bad news is that until we reach a stable equilibrium, there are no detour attacks, more inter-State wars that grind on by attrition are possible. It is a scary thought, but one we must brace for.

Sreeram Chaulia is dean, Jindal School of International Affairs. The views expressed are personal

Legislation needs debate, not blind determination

Parliament's Monsoon Session, which commenced on July 20 and is on till August 13, has been marked by a series of confrontations on issues surfacing both within and outside Parliament. Two bills, introduced in earlier sessions of Parliament (but not tabled yet), merit greater discussion and scrutiny: the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment, or FCRA, Bill, 2026, and the Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill, 2025. Both not just expand executive control, but also remove all space for an independent decision-maker. The two bills need to be read against a decade of precedents describing the same institutional habit: Whenever a court or a federal structure has stood between the Centre and a decision it wanted to make alone, the response has been to legislate the obstacle away.

The FCRA Bill, introduced on March 25, was framed as tidying up 'legal gaps'. Internally, it does something larger by inserting a new Chapter, IIA, into the FCRA Act, 2001, creating a Designated Authority that, under Section 18C, wields powers resembling a civil court's in order to supervise, manage, or permanently vest in itself any foreign-fund asset — hospitals, schools, etc. — the moment a registration is cancelled, suspended, or allowed to lapse.

The ministry that cancels a licence effectively appoints the authority that then disposes of what the organisation built, with proceeds flowing to the Consolidated Fund of India. The scale is not trivial; the government's dashboard shows over 22,000 registrations have already been cancelled and roughly 15,000 left not renewed as of April 2026, making for a population of institutions already standing to be impacted by the mechanism now being written into law.

This is also not a first move. The original FCRA, enacted during the Emergency in 1976, targeted political funding, the 2010 Act broadened oversight of NGOs, the 2020 amendment mandated a single State Bank of India account, curbed permissible administrative spending from 50% to 20%, made Aadhaar mandatory for office-bearers, and banned the onward transfer of funds between organisations. Each iteration has tightened the State's grip on the same sector. The 2026 Bill is the point at which oversight of funds becomes ownership of assets.

Constitutional scholars flag conflict with Article 304A, since the Authority can act alone of any judicial finding, and with Article 30, which guarantees minorities the right to run their own educational institutions, a concern sharpened by Rules notified in June labelling organisations engaged in 'proselytisation', a term the law does not define, from FCRA eligibility altogether. The government invokes the Financial Action Task Force (FATF), yet the FATF's 2024 review found India only partially compliant on non-profit safeguards and asked for a targeted, risk-based approach, not a blanket mechanism across the sector. A UN Special Rapporteur had flagged the FCRA's chilling effect on associational freedom in 2016; a decade later, the amendment answers that warning by expanding the very power it criticised.

The Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill performs a parallel manoeuvre against a different check-judicial conviction. It follows directly from Arvind Kejriwal governing Delhi from Thiruvallur in 2024 with no mandate resigning. Introduced in the Lok Sabha last August and sent to a Joint Parliamentary Committee in

November, it would amend Articles 75, 164, and 239AA so that a prime minister, Union minister, chief minister, or state minister held in custody for 30 consecutive days, on a charge carrying five years' imprisonment or more, must resign by the 31st day or automatically cease to hold office. Custody, set by an investigating agency's sting and a bail order, replaces conviction that is decided by a court after trial, as the trigger for removing an elected head of government.

That the Bill reaches for Article 239AA is not incidental. This is the same provision the Supreme Court interpreted in May 2023, ruling unanimously that Delhi's elected government held control over its administrative services and that this 'chain of accountability' was essential to representative government. Within eight days, the Centre issued an Ordinance overriding that verdict, later enacted as the GNCTD (Amendment) Act, 2023, handing control to the Lieutenant Governor, answerable to the Centre.

The 130th Amendment Bill proposes to amend the same article, but in a different way, and time for a different purpose, but to the same effect: reducing what a court decision protects. Several Opposition parties have boycotted the Joint Committee on the ground that whoever controls the tempo of arrests and bail hearings would, in effect, control the removal of rivals from office. The panel, headed by BJP MP Aparajita Sarangi, is understood to have retained the 30-day clause while adding unspecified 'safeguards', yet, on July 17, days before the session began, it deferred even adopting that report, seeking further consultation.

The government would appear to be testing the limits of the Opposition, the judiciary and the public. There is a pattern to how this government legises: it is understood to have turned to a textbook case of this.

None of this makes foreign-funding oversight and ministerial accountability illegitimate as reforms; each deserves attention. But a two-thirds majority assembled through defection and merger to tighten executive control is not the sustained public persuasion Article 368 was written to demand. Civil society and an elected rival, both in their own Bill, are being asked to trust a discretion the texts of the respective Bills do not constrain.

A close look at the data on parliamentary performance reveals a qualitative decline — a legislature transformed into a rubber-stamping exercise seen so far, where extra hours are utilised to move legislation faster rather than to sharpen the law. In June, the government session on the Houses appears less like a debating chamber and more like a corporate board meeting where the decisions were made long before the attendees arrived. When arithmetic substitutes for argument, what Parliament explains matters less than what it never had to explain. Governments' ambitions and desires are clear, their executive upholding is apparent. The end goal is no longer blowing in the wind. One must have their eyes wide shut to think otherwise.

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{ ABHIJEET DIPKE | FOUNDER, COCKROACH JANITA PARTY }

We don't need to look at Bangladesh or Nepal when we have Mahatma Gandhi from whom the world takes inspiration to protest



Insurance firms as major stakeholders in cleaner air

As policymakers debate how to clean Delhi-NCR's air, a striking comparison has emerged. Recent analysis suggests that around ₹5,000 crore of targeted public support could significantly accelerate the electrification of heavy trucks in the region, delivering substantial air-quality benefits. Health insurers may roughly the same amount every year in air-pollution-related hospitalisation claims in Delhi alone. The comparison raises the question: If pollution imposes a direct and growing financial cost on insurers, shouldn't they become active investors in prevention?

Air quality-linked illnesses now constitute 9% of all hospitalisation claims in India, up from 6.4% in 2022. Delhi alone to just 2.5% of India's population, accounts for 38% of hospitalisation claims attributable to poor air quality. The insurance industry's reported discussions with the Department of Health and Family Welfare, and the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority (IRDAI) on a 10-15% premium loading for Delhi residents reflect this reality.

According to the IRDAI Annual Report 2024-25, health insurers paid roughly ₹8.00 in claims for every rupee of premium collected. With air pollution accounting for an estimated 9-9% of claims, the industry's annual pollution-linked payout burden may exceed ₹7,500 crore. In Delhi alone, as mentioned earlier, insurers are estimated to pay around ₹1,000 crore annually for far-exceeding public expenditure on air quality improvement.

The Union government recently announced a vehicle replacement scheme for Delhi-NCR, which has regained debate on transport emissions. Some analysts argue that stronger incentives for electric grid vehicles could deliver significantly larger air-quality benefits. Viewed differently, the NCR vehicle replacement scheme may have inadvertently created the perfect pilot for testing an air quality improvement market: a defined geography, measurable interventions, established monitoring systems, identifiable beneficiaries, and a potential buyer base in the insurance sector with an economic interest in cleaner air.

India already has a policy instrument that could provide the architecture for such a pilot. The Green Credit Programme (GCP), launched in 2023, is designed to monetise verified environmental improvements, such as the Carbon Credit and Trading Scheme (CCTS), the GCP is not narrowly focused on emissions. With an appropriate methodology, the programme could potentially be extended to recognise verified air-quality improve-

ments, creating a mechanism through which their environmental value can be measured and monetised. A 2022 study using health insurance records in China found that every 10 µg/m³ reduction in PM_{2.5} reduced healthcare expenditure for respiratory and circulatory ailments by 18%. Applied to India, where the average insured air-quality-related hospitalisation costs ₹55,263, the savings can be substantial.

Insurers can begin immediately by directing CSR funds towards air quality interventions and measuring the impact on claims. They can also participate as investors in green bonds and other sustainable-finance instruments linked to emissions reduction. To scale such instruments, IRDAI should clarify whether verified green credits qualify as permissible investment assets. This would allow insurers to deploy investment capital, and not merely CSR budgets, towards reducing future underwriting risks.

Over time, new instruments akin to impact bonds could link verified air-quality improvements directly to reduced healthcare costs, creating a self-reinforcing market for prevention. Measurement is the foundation on which this model rests. India already possesses strong air pollution monitoring infrastructure. What is missing is a standardised, independently verified attribution methodology for green credits. India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) could strengthen this ecosystem further. A citizen choosing public transport on a Red AQI day could receive a green credit in their Digi Locker wallet. This approach leverages DPI to deliver measurable public health and air-quality outcomes.

The logic of insurers investing to reduce covered risk is not new. India's first air-quality-based parametric insurance product was introduced in 2025, covering construction workers in Delhi with automatic payouts when AQI exceeds 400. While parametric insurance remains reactive, it points toward a future where insurers invest upstream to reduce claims altogether. India's insurance sector has an opportunity to move from being a passive bearer of air-pollution costs to an active participant in reducing them. Achieving this will require coordinated action across insurers, IRDAI, government agencies, auditors, and API actors.

Ashok Kumar Thankonda is India program lead at the Global Green Growth Institute (GGGI) and Pawan Mulukutla is executive program director for Integrated Transport, Clean Air and Hydrogen, WRI India. The views expressed are personal

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Aung San Suu Kyi with ICRC representative Arnaud de Baeque, AFP

Suu Kyi meets Red Cross official

NAYPYITAW: Myanmar's detained former leader Aung San Suu Kyi met with a representative of the International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) on Monday, after years of questions over the health and well-being of the 81-year-old Nobel Peace Prize winner. **REUTERS**

Normalcy returns in Nepal districts

KATHMANDU: Normalcy returned to southern Nepal's Madhesh and Koshi provinces on Monday as the law and order situation improved following days of communal violence in the region bordering India. Three people were killed in the clashes, which soon spread to neighbouring areas. **PTI**

8mn books burnt in Russian strike

KYIV: A Russian strike on a warehouse in northeastern Ukraine over the weekend destroyed eight million books, the publishing house said on Monday, slamming it as an attack on Ukrainian culture. "More than 8 million books have been destroyed in the fire, among them textbooks for children," the publisher Ranko said on social media. **AFP**

Talks with Iran on, Tehran has one last chance, says Trump

Reuters & AFP

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WASHINGTON/NEW YORK: US President Donald Trump on Monday said talks with Iran "are going on right now", adding that the negotiations represented the last chance for Tehran to sign a good deal.

Earlier on Monday, after Iran said there were no talks under way, Trump slammed what he called Iran's "unbelievably duplicitous" leadership.

"They are going on right now," Trump told reporters when asked about the status of the negotiations, saying the two sides were talking at the request of Iran, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates and Qatar among others.

"This is a last chance for them to sign a good document," he said, referring to Iran.

The Iranian foreign ministry said on Monday that the only talks it was holding were with Oman to discuss plans for sharing control over the Strait of Hormuz, a vital passage for the global energy trade.

The Strait, Trump insisted, "is already completely controlled by the United States Navy and our 'Blockade' or, as some say, 'The United States Wall of Steel'." Nothing gets through to Iran, unless we want it to, and nothing will get through, unless a Deal, or Total Surrender, is accomplished.

Over the weekend, Trump repeated a pattern that has emerged throughout the past five months: announcing plans for "massive attacks" on Iran, only to cancel them at the last minute. "Would I rather make a deal? I'm not looking to kill people," Trump said aboard Air Force One on Sunday.

"Now what we're doing is talking to them, in the form of a



An Iranian man walks past an anti-US billboard at Enghelab Square in central Tehran on Monday. **AFP**

TWO TANKERS WITH SAUDI OIL, EXIT RED SEA OVER WEEKEND

SINGAPORE: Two tankers laden with Saudi oil crossed the Bab el-Mandeb Strait over the weekend, while traffic in the Strait of Hormuz slowed following reports of vessel attacks, shipping data showed on Monday. Suezmax tanker Lesvos and Very Large Crude Carrier Desh Valbhav exited the Red Sea with their Automatic Identification Systems (AIS) transponders switched off.

The Desh Valbhav, carrying 2 million barrels, is heading to India's Sikkim port. **REUTERS**

negotiation. It begins tomorrow afternoon," he said, without identifying a venue or participants for such talks.

Monday's developments appeared to fit a pattern that has emerged since Trump launched "Operation Epic Fury" alongside Israel more than five months ago. On several occasions, Trump has threatened military action only to later cite

diplomatic contacts as a reason for stepping back.

Oil prices drop 5%

Oil prices fell about 5% to a three-week low on Monday after US President Donald Trump held off on a fresh attack on Iran in the hope of sealing a quick deal that could boost oil supplies from the Gulf.

Brent futures fell \$4.19, or 4.8%, to \$83.74 a barrel at 12:40pm ET (16:40 GMT), while US West Texas Intermediate (WTI) crude fell \$4.32, or 5.8%, to \$79.75. That put Brent on track for its lowest close since July 13 due in part to the start of the less expensive October futures as the front-month after the more expensive September contract expired on Friday.

Six Saudi-flagged supertankers have changed course in the Gulf of Aden in recent days and are heading to southern Africa following threats by the Iran-backed Houthi movement in Yemen to target Saudi shipping, tracking data showed on Monday.

JAPAN AND U.S. PROP UP YEN IN RARE JOINT MOVE, SIGNAL READINESS FOR MORE ACTION

Reuters

letters@hindustantimes.com

TOKYO: Japan and the United States conducted coordinated yen-buying intervention and will not hesitate to take further action, Japan's finance ministry said on Monday, confirming a rare bilateral action to halt the yen's slide to fresh 40-year lows.

The intervention on Friday underscored both countries' resolve to prevent a self-off in the yen and Japanese government bonds (JGBs) from causing global spillovers, such as adding upward pressure on already rising US Treasury yields, analysts said.

The joint intervention was the first since 2011's coordinated action to weaken the yen following the devastating earthquake in eastern Japan.

Central bank data indicated on Monday that Japan may have spent as much as \$36.58 billion buying yen during Friday's joint intervention. The US Treasury sold euros to buy yen, three sources familiar with the matter said.

President Donald Trump said on Sunday the United States was helping Japan prop up the yen as a sign of friendship and to help the world economy. Aside from helping Japan as a strategic ally in Asia, the intervention would help the US address concerns over extraordinary weakness in the yen that offsets the boost from Trump's tariffs, analysts say.

In the statement, Japan's finance ministry said Friday's yen-buying intervention with the US Treasury Department "countered excessive volatility and disorderly movements in the Japanese yen in recent months."

"We will not hesitate conducting further coordinated intervention," Finance Minister Satsuki Katayama told reporters on Monday.

The yen surged more than 1% to 155.20 per dollar after the announcement, its strongest since early May and well off the 40-year low near 164 hit last month, as traders remained on alert for more intervention. It was trading around 157 per dollar late on Monday.

Greece and France battle wildfires; drought in UK

Associated Press & Reuters

letters@hindustantimes.com

ATHENS/BUCHAREST: A record-breaking hot and dry summer tightened its grip on Europe on Monday, as water-dropping planes swooped over a major wildfire in Greece, firefighters in France sought to stabilise a blaze in Provence, and much of the UK recorded its driest July in nearly two centuries.

Wildfires west of Athens jumped containment lines, a day after a mid-air collision between two helicopters killed two crew members.

In France, firefighters in the region around Bordeaux guarded against potential flare-ups inside a still-burning scar four times the size of Paris.

A prolonged heatwave and lack of rainfall led to the driest July in England and Wales in nearly 200 years of recordkeeping, according to provisional statistics, the UK's weather service said Monday.

All of Wales and more than half of England are officially in



A helicopter dumps water to control a wildfire in Mount Kithirionas, near Psatha, west of Athens, on Monday. **REUTERS**

drought, the Met Office said. The dry spell was accompanied by sweltering temperatures across much of the UK, following heat waves in May and June.

Wales tied its record for its warmest mean temperature for July while England and the UK recorded their second-warmest July. Strong winds returned to southern Greece late Monday, pushing flames into mountain

home clusters, destroying farms and property, and closing a highway.

Firefighters in the Netherlands were battling a large blaze Monday in a forest in the southern province of Limburg, authorities said, as the country sweltered through another day of hot, dry summer weather. The national railway operator halted trains between two towns in the area due to the fire.

Romania blasts rocks to reroute cooling Danube water to nuclear reactor

Romania blew up a rock outcrop on Monday to help redirect vital cooling water from the drought-hit Danube river to its sole working nuclear reactor, an unprecedented measure underlining the scale of an energy crunch across the region.

In neighbouring Hungary, authorities said they might be able to ease out two more days of power from their only atomic plant, which has been hit by falling levels in the Danube that it also relies on as a coolant.

Milei doubles down on Lula, now calls him 'thief', 'corrupt'

Buenos Aires:

Argentina's President Javier Milei renewed his war of words against leftist Brazilian counterpart Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva on Sunday, after sparking a diplomatic spat last week by calling him a criminal.

"He's a thief, he's corrupt, he's been convicted of theft and corruption, he's been in prison, so it's true that we can call him a convict," Milei said of Lula during an interview on LN+.

The libertarian Argentine leader made similar remarks during a speech in Brazil last weekend supporting Flavio Bolsonaro, Lula's right-wing opponent in the upcoming presidential election. Brazil recalled its ambassador to Argentina for



Javier Milei, Lula da Silva

consultations over Milei's speech, which also took aim at a Brazilian Supreme Court justice.

Buenos Aires later sought to play down the spat with its largest trade partner, with presidential spokesperson Adrian Ravier saying it was a matter of "ideological and political differences." Asked on Sunday why he

had such aggressiveness towards Lula, Milei retorted: "Don't you think it's aggressive when someone steals from you? Calling a thief a 'thief' is far less serious than the act of stealing itself."

"They released him (Lula) because of an administrative error, not because he's innocent. Therefore, he's a thief and a corrupt official," the Argentine leader insisted. "I'm doing this because I'm a champion of the ideals of freedom," he added.

Lula, who was previously president from 2003-2010, spent 580 days in jail beginning in April 2018 after being convicted in the sprawling Operation Car Wash anti-corruption probe. **AFP**

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Nabi's Test call-up reward for excelling in Ranji Trophy

An ideal red-ball bowler who relies on swing and seam, he replaces the injured Bumrah for the Test series in Sri Lanka

Sanjeev K Samyal
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MUMBAI: Former India captain and chief selector Dilip Vengsarkar maintains that the most important thing is to pick a player when he is in form and doing well.

In domestic cricket, no one is in better rhythm than Aqib Nabi. The Jammu and Kashmir pacer has delivered back-to-back blockbuster seasons. Nabi claimed 104 wickets across the last two Ranji Trophy seasons, including 60 wickets in the 2025-26 campaign, playing a pivotal role in Jammu and Kashmir's maiden Ranji Trophy triumph.

After such a brilliant show, it was a given that he would be an automatic pick for India's one-off Test against Afghanistan in June at New Chandigarh. To the disbelief of cricket fans, Nabi's name was missing when the team was announced.

Nabi was also not picked in the original squad for the upcoming two-Test series in Sri Lanka either.

However, strike bowler Jasprit Bumrah not recovering from his knee injury has paved the way for the 29-year-old's inclusion as a replacement.

When a deserving candidate's selection is delayed the fear is that he may lose motivation. The break thus could not have come at a better time. It is reward for his toil and fine performance.

"It's a big achievement for Nabi because he has set an example for all those in India who are playing in the domestic circuit," says P. Krishna Kumar, Nabi's bowling coach.

Now they can have the belief that if you do well in the domestic circuit, you can play for India," said P. Krishna Kumar, Nabi's bowling coach.



Aqib Nabi (C) was named in the India test squad as replacement for injured Jasprit Bumrah.

for the last three seasons with Jammu and Kashmir.

"I knew this route is very long; for example, if someone is playing IPL, it's a shorter route because you get a chance to play against the top players of the world, and if you perform

you get selected for India. But not everyone can play IPL. This (Nabi's selection) has given the belief to all aspiring cricketers. That is the biggest message that has gone in the domestic circuit," said Kumar, who played 70 first-class games

and is now the fast bowling coach at BCCI's Centre of Excellence, Bengaluru.

How important was the belief that Nabi got this break? "Only last week he was at the Centre of Excellence. He was slightly down that he was not getting

the chance. But the best thing about Nabi is he has got a cool head on his shoulders. I told him,

"Don't worry, selection is not in your hand. You can only control what you can and take wickets." He said, "Absolutely, you're right sir," as he works hard getting ready for the Duleep Trophy.

"Now by God's grace, he has got a chance in a Test series. His selection has been blessed."

Nabi, who hails from a remote village in Kashmir's Baramulla, is the third J&K player to get a senior India call-up, after Parvez Rasool and Umran Malik, who both played limited-over cricket.

India's seam attack for Sri Lanka includes Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna and Gurnoor Brar.

He may have to wait for his turn, but he is in good rhythm. To his advantage, he is well versed with the conditions in Sri Lanka as he was in the India A squad that toured recently, where he took six wickets in two first-class games.

Nabi missed out in the first place because the selectors and team management preferred extra pace and bounce, qualities the taller Brar offers.

Nabi's strength is his mastery over moving the ball with accuracy.

An out and out strike bowler, the Kashmiri makes for a great sight – batters being bowled through the gate, trapped while shouldering arms.

Describing his style of bowling, in an earlier interview to this newspaper, Nabi said: "I look to) Hit the right areas from where you have a higher chance of taking wickets. That is how I look to bowl, bowl outswinging, inswing from the same spot. The key to my success is to be focussed and hit the right areas."

"Whichever wicket is there, whether it is flat or helpful, my mindset is to hit the good areas, irrespective of wickets or batters, and move the ball from there, bowl with patience. It helps me a lot if you keep things simple."

England's factory reset after Bazball adventure

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KOLKATA: For the better part of a decade now England's Test team have tried to answer the wrong question. Lurching from one extreme to another, confusing style for substance, philosophy for performance, capitulating in some of the biggest tours and eventually showing up with barely anything, England could be excused for thinking they have thrived.

They have, to be fair, in bits and parts, never to go all the way. These four years under Brendon McCullum and Ben Stokes was a dizzying ride of fast-forward cricket with heavy talwind, taking England on the scenic route but ending up at the same place.

It makes England's decision of reverting to Joe Root as captain and Stephen Fleming as coach remarkable. It's not just a rebalancing act but a factory reset of settings that England discarded after facing accusations of being timid, conservative and trapped by convention, the last straw a 10-wicket defeat at Barbados in March, 2022.

Four years since that defeat, with the Bazball experiment finally shelved following another Ashes humiliation in Australia and a chastening home draw to India, England have arrived at an equally uncomfortable destination: spectacularly entertaining, undeniably influential, but scarcely more successful.

The numbers are chastening too. A better win-loss ratio (1.35) in these four years compared to the phase before that, yet, by equal number of defeats (20) in fewer Tests. Significantly, only two draws since 2022 compared to nine in the phase before doesn't exactly strengthen the argument that a team would prefer losing than drawing because the whole concept of staying undefeated is any day better on paper as it encompasses wins and draws.

That is why the appointment of Root and Fleming feels less the ushering in of a new era and more an admission that England have spent four years chasing an illusion. With McCullum there was

England in 5 years before Bazball				
SPAN	Won	Lost	Draw	
2018-2022	22	20	9	
Matches: 51				
RPO: 3.12				

England during Bazball				
SPAN	Won	Lost	Draw	
2022-2026	27	20	2	
Matches: 49				
RPO: 4.44				

never any tactical framework to fall back on. It was all impulse and barely any patience. Even before England had played a Test, Bazball had become a cultural identity, a marketing slogan and, eventually, a shield against criticism. Winning became disclike, playing the right way became essential. And along the way, England forgot that Test cricket has always rewarded balance over absolutism.

That, perhaps, is Bazball's greatest paradox: It changed the conversation around Test cricket more than it changed England's fortunes within it. For a while, the revolution felt irresistible. But as opponents adapted, Bazball's greatest strengths slowly revealed their greatest weaknesses. Teams stopped being intimidated by England's relentless aggression.

The scoreboard reflected the shift. Australia dismantled them in the Ashes. India outplayed them at home in 2024. Away from familiar pitches, Bazball increasingly looked like a clickbait story than a sustainable blueprint.

The finest Test teams have always attacked Steve Waugh's Australia hunted victories on the most foreign of pitches. Graeme Smith's South Africa squeezed opponents with relentless discipline until they cracked. Under Virat Kohli, India chased wins in all conditions. Stokes' greatest innings remain monuments to calculated aggression.

But calculation was what Bazball gradually abandoned. There appeared to be only one acceptable tempo, mindset, and response to adversity. Context, that most

precious currency in Test cricket, had quietly become secondary to commitment.

Now comes the inevitable correction. Root's return as captain is symbolic beyond the obvious, given how Stokes proved a psychologically draining factor for England in recent months. Root's instinct has always been to let situations breathe before acting. Fleming, meanwhile, has built one of modern sport's most admired coaching reputations through clarity, preparation and emotional restraint. His Chennai Super Kings have rarely been the loudest team, but almost always the smartest.

With them, England are effectively admitting that emotional control may provide a greater advantage than emotional liberation. There is no doubt England have rediscovered an attacking instinct that had almost vanished from their DNA. Yet they were undermined by an institutional refusal to recognise that every strength carries its own limits.

History is unlikely to judge Bazball by its marketing success. It will judge by whether England became the world's best Test team. They didn't get even close to being one. Instead, England spent four years searching for an identity when what they truly needed was steady progress. The result is a team that has travelled a full circle – from being too cautious to being too carefree – and finally returned to being moderate. In their journey lies the template of what not to do in a format that keeps finding ways to challenge cricket on several levels.



Dev Lakra of Purani Dilli 6 in action in DPL.

Lakra guides Purani Dilli 6 to easy victory

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: Dev Lakra's explosive half-century and captain Anuj Rawat's composed finish powered Purani Dilli 6 to a seven-wicket win over West Delhi Lions in the first of the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Monday. Chasing 181, Purani Dilli endured the worst possible start when Rohan Rana fell off the first ball of the innings. But the setback barely slowed them down as Lakra (64 off 33) and Samarth Seth (30 off 29) stitched together a 94-run stand for the second wicket.

After Lakra's dismissal, Rawat ensured there were no further

hiccups, finishing unbeaten on 49 off 26 balls. Earlier, West Delhi Lions posted 180/6 after opener Ankit Kumar hit 86 off 45 balls. Alongside Krish Yadav (43 off 31), he added 90 runs for the opening wicket. However, regular wickets in the latter half of the innings prevented the Lions from pushing beyond 180.

In the second match of the day, Central Delhi Kings chased down 210 against North Delhi Strikers to register a four-wicket win and continue their unbeaten run. Yash Bhatia scored a brilliant 90* off 51 to help set up 209/3 but Jonny Sidhu (75 off 38) and Aditya Bhandari (46 off 24) kept their nerves to seal their win in 18.2 overs.

Harshita 1st Indian in Tour de France Femmes
AIGLE: Cyclist Harshita Jakhar rode into history books by becoming the first Indian to be a part of the Tour de France Femmes. The 19-year-old led a pack of eight talented cyclists from Afghanistan, Algeria, Chile, Ethiopia (two riders), Namibia and Uganda during the ceremonial start at Stage 2 of the race on Sunday. The event started on August 1 in Lausanne and will end on August 9 in Nice.

Chelsea sign England midfielder Henderson
LONDON: Chelsea announced the signing of veteran England midfielder Jordan Henderson from Brentford. The former Liverpool captain, who was part of England's World Cup squad, has signed a two-year deal at Stamford Bridge. "Given the size of the club, the manager, who I have great admiration for, and the quality of the players, this was a huge opportunity I couldn't turn down," said Henderson.

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